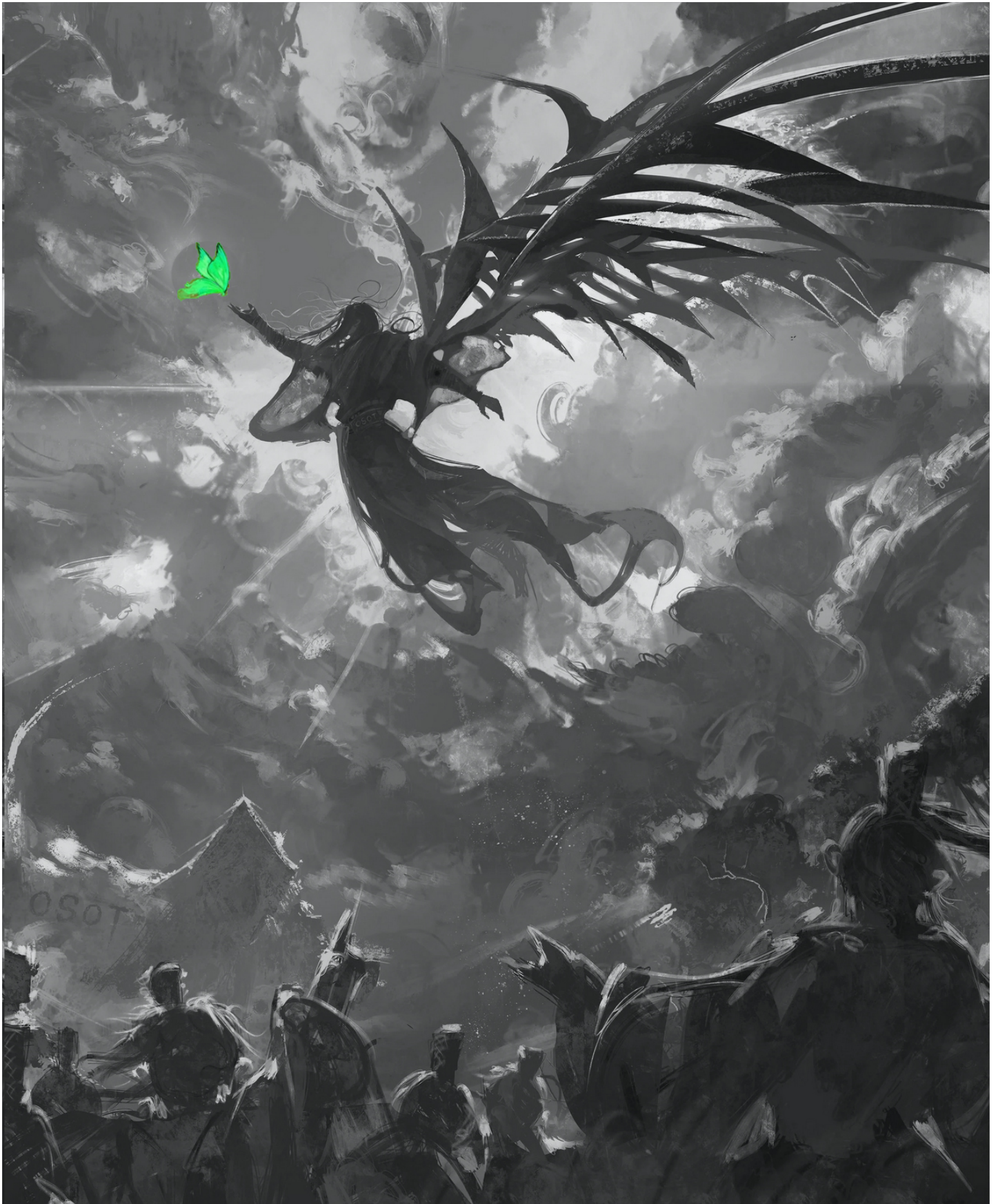


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Chapter 1: Introduction

System and Setting

This system is based on the world of the xianxia novel Reverend Insanity (aka Master of Gu) by Gu Zhen Ren. In short, it is a high-magic system where most characters and all players are spellcasters called Gu Masters. Spells are contained within creatures called Gu, which can be stored inside a Gu Master's body. Each Gu has a specific function, and the way your character will play is going to constantly change as your personal collection of Gu changes. If you specialize in Fire Path and later decide you'd rather beat your enemies to death with Strength Path, you can sell your Gu and buy, find, or create new ones to fulfill that purpose, or dual cultivate the paths for a unique playstyle.

Southern Border: Master of Gu is primarily a game about tactical combat, and using resources wisely out of combat to improve your battle strength. Roleplaying is still central to the game, but you would be better served by a different system if you're looking for low-combat gameplay.

The Aperture

The aperture is a sort of extra-dimensional space located in a Gu Master's stomach. Around the age of puberty, people can awaken their aperture by coming into contact with Hope Gu. Not everyone is lucky enough to be able to awaken their aperture, but those that do are henceforth called Gu Masters. People without an awakened aperture are called mortals, and are just regular people.

The aperture is a simple sphere bounded by walls and filled with a sea of primeval essence, a resource used to activate Gu as well as to cultivate. Cultivation consists of attacking your aperture walls with this primeval essence, eventually breaking them and moving on to a new realm. Each rank is considered a large realm, and are subdivided into 4 small realms: initial stage, middle stage, upper stage, and peak stage. After rank 5, there are still ranks 6 through 9, but that is the realm of Gu Immortals and the rules change massively. In this system, Gu Masters begin at rank 1 initial stage, and the maximum rank attainable is rank 5 peak stage.

You can store Gu in your aperture no matter their size, and there is no limit to the number of Gu that can be stored in your aperture. The aperture is accessible to its owner at any time through their thoughts, but other creatures can only access someone else's aperture after they are dead or through the use of special Gu.

Primeval Essence

Primeval essence is the main resource used by Gu masters to activate and refine Gu as well as cultivate to increase their strength. The representation of primeval essence you see here is an approximation, as the resource quickly becomes quite complex when factoring in the rank and realm of the user alongside the rank of the Gu.

A Gu Master's aperture has a maximum amount of primeval essence, determined by their aptitude. At the initial stage of each rank, a Gu Master has a number of portions of primeval essence equal to their aptitude. A Gu Master at rank 2 initial stage with a 30% aptitude (D-Grade) has a maximum of 30 portions of primeval essence.

When out of combat, the recovery rate is 10% of the Gu Master's maximum primeval essence every hour. Each small realm above initial stage doubles the maximum number of portions available.

At higher ranks, your primeval essence is significantly more potent than that of the rank below you. For simplicity, activating any Gu of a rank below your own costs a single portion of primeval essence.

As a **Bonus Action**, you may leak the aura of your primeval essence. Any creature within 10 meters of you can sense this aura and immediately identify the rank and stage of your primeval essence.

Primeval Stones

Small, smooth stones naturally formed from primeval essence, primeval stones are the main currency in the Gu world. On your turn, you can absorb the essence of a number of primeval stones equal to the number of hands you have as a **Combat Action**. You must have one hand free for each stone being absorbed.

For each primeval stone being absorbed, you gain {30, 20, 10, 4, 1}¹ portion(s) of primeval essence, and the stone is destroyed in the process, crumbling into dust.

You can carry up to 250 primeval stones on your person, but many storage type Gu exist to hold additional stones.

Refinement

Gu can be created out of materials and other Gu in a process called refinement. See the *Gu* chapter for more details.

¹ When you see curly brace notation, it represents your rank, or the rank of the Gu if it appears in a Gu's description. In this case, it means expending a primeval stone restores 30 primeval essence if you are rank 1, 20 if you are rank 2, and so on.

The World

The Gu world is a massive, flat disc, consisting of 5 regions. The source material is pretty inconsistent with size, but it is safe to say each region is at least 6 or 7 times the surface area of the Earth.

- **Northern Plains:** Flat grassland dotted with nomadic tribes of various sizes. Conflict is commonplace and the Gu Masters here are the most adept at fighting.
- **Western Desert:** A dry wasteland with cities gathered around its oases. Lone cultivators are very uncommon.
- **Southern Border:** An uneven, mountainous region with familial clans settling on mountainsides. The setting of this system.
- **Eastern Sea:** Vast ocean dotted with archipelagos. Conflict is less common due to difficulty in reaching other settlements, allowing its inhabitants to focus on cultivation and gaining wealth. Many lone cultivators.
- **Central Continent:** The most powerful of the five regions and home to the Heavenly Court. Has a mix of the other four regions' geography (i.e. a normal continent).

Since the world is a disc, Southern Border does not border Northern Plains, but it does border the other regions. The same goes for the other outer regions, with only Central Continent connecting to all of them.

Mortals

People without an awakened aperture cannot use Gu. Their status is very low, and in most places a Gu Master can outright kill any mortals that disrespect them. Despite that, mortals do a great deal of work to provide food and resources to the clan, and cannot be wantonly murdered without reproach from righteous path forces.

Righteous and Demonic

Gu Masters identify as part of either the demonic path or righteous path. Demonic does not necessarily mean evil, just that the Gu Master does not follow the rigid systems of community. Of course, many demonic path Gu Masters ARE evil and more than willing to hurt the innocent to further their own goals. Similarly, righteous path Gu Masters are not necessarily good, they just follow the rules of society. While many have ideals of justice and virtue, the more powerful righteous path Gu Masters exploit this societal responsibility for their own gain, and are often willing to commit evil deeds to further their goals, just in more subtle ways than the demonic path.

Inheritances

Inheritances are a common aspect of the Gu World's culture; a Gu Master's ideals can live on long after their death by leaving an inheritance of Gu, refinement recipes, and information to be found in the future. Some inheritances are fraught with difficulty, fully capable of killing those that seek to claim them. Others are safe but with measures to ensure the inheritor is someone worthy of the prize. Sometimes a Gu Master just leaves some Gu in a cave with food and hopes for the best.

Chapter 5 is dedicated to Southern Border, its clans, and geography. It is heavily recommended for the Game Master to read it.

The Dice Mechanic

Skill Tests

Skill tests (and Attribute tests, which are much less common) are rolled when a character would like to do an action or is forced to do an action that:

- has a chance of failure
- has a chance of success

The GM should be able to determine if an action is possible for your character to do, as well as if the action should be an automatic success.

Dice

Dice are notated d[sides]; a d4 is a 4 sided die. The td10 is a 10 sided die where each value is a tens place (10, 20, 30, etc). If instead of the number of dice, the die is annotated with an R (Rd12), then the number of dice is equal to the rank of the Gu. This system uses d4, d6, d8, d10, td10, d12, and d20.

The d100

Tests are rolled on a d100; to roll a d100, roll a d10 and a td10. The td10 represents the tens place while the d10 represents the ones place. So if you roll an 80 and a 5, your roll is 85. Rolling a 10 on the d10 is just a zero, so rolling 90 and 10 would just be 90. Finally, rolling 00 on the td10 and a 10 on the d10 is 100.

When you take an action, the GM decides what skill that action is related to, determines penalties or bonuses, and then you roll a d100. If your result is equal to or lower than your skill, you succeeded, and can determine degrees of success if they effect the outcome of the action.

If the result is higher than your skill, you fail, and the GM determines the consequences.

Penalty/Bonus	Difficulty
+120	Impossible (Traveling against the Reverse Flow River)
+100	Unheard of (Refining an Immortal Gu)
+80	Impossible without the use of Gu (Trading a Gu for a higher ranked one)
+60	Extreme Difficulty (Identifying a very rare Gu)
+40	High Difficulty (Convincing a Wisdom Path master to change their plans)
+20	Difficult (Cultivating with minor distractions)
0	Challenging (Identifying an uncommon Gu)
-20	Slightly Challenging (Refining a common Gu)
-40	Simple (Identifying poisonous plants around your clan's walls)
-60	Trivial (Haggling a merchant to take a few primeval stones off a large price)

Penalties and Bonuses

Penalties and bonuses are a number added or subtracted from the number you roll on the die during a skill test. The GM can add either to represent the difficulty of the check, using the table on the previous page as a guideline. Many Gu and conditions will also apply penalties or bonuses that are added on top of the difficulty. Penalties and bonuses do not have to be round multiples of 10, but they typically are.

Advantage and Disadvantage

If you have advantage on a test, roll an additional d10 and take the lower of the two. You can stack advantages as long as they come from different sources. Disadvantage works the same way, but you take the higher of the d10 rolls.

Help

You can help another creature with a skill test as a **Combat Action**. You must be able to explain what action you are taking to help them on the skill test, and if the GM allows it they can give the helped creature up to a -30 bonus on their skill test, depending on the action taken.

Degrees of Success/Failure

A success automatically has 1 degree of success, and a failure has 1 degree of failure. For every 10 you roll below/above your skill value, you gain an additional degree of success/failure, respectively. Some skill tests, such as an opposed Deception/Insight roll, do not take degrees of success into account; they're either deceived or they aren't. Many tests, however, will have different effects based on the degrees of success or failure.

Critical

When you roll at or under 1/10 of your skill's value (rounded down, minimum 1) on the die, you've landed a critical. Criticals are automatic successes, though degrees of success are still calculated like normal with a minimum of 1. Some skills have a critical success effect built into them, though the GM can always add a special additional success to any test you critically succeed.

If you score a critical with an attack roll, the attack deals double the damage it normally would.

Fumble

Fumbles occur when 99-100 is rolled on the die for a skill test. If your skill value is above 99, you only fumble on a roll of 100 for that skill. Fumbles are an automatic failure, though degrees of failure are still calculated like normal with a minimum of 1.

Opposed Tests

When competing with your skills against another creature, the two of you may be called to make an Opposed Test. You both roll a skill test, which can be for the same or different skills, and compare results. Critical successes beat any non-critical roll, and fumbles lose to any non-fumble roll. Then, the player with the most degrees of success or least degrees of failure wins. If they're tied for degrees of success/failure, then the lower number on the die wins. If they're still tied, the Opposed Test ends in a tie if possible. If the Opposed Test can't be tied, then the involved parties make the test again until they do not tie.

Running the Game

Materials

To run the game, you will need a full set of dice including a d4, d6, d8, d10, d12, and d20. Additionally, each player will need a character sheet and something to write with. This game is intended to be played with miniatures on a grid.

The Game Master

One Player must act as the Game Master (GM), or *Heaven's Will* if you prefer. The GM runs the game, creates the encounters and story, and has the final say on everything that happens during the course of play.

Quirks

This system has some mechanics that don't work like most ttrpgs. Stealth does not exist as a skill, for example; whoever is trying to sneak will specify what they are doing to stay undetected, and then whoever is able to perceive them makes an **Awareness** skill test with a bonus or penalty depending on the circumstances. See **Chapter 4: Combat** for more details.

Another unique aspect are the Attitude (basically charisma) based skills; player characters are the only things that can make Attitude based skill tests such as **Persuasion** and **Deception**; when NPCs are trying to persuade, deceive, intimidate, or haggle with a player character, it is entirely up to the player what their reaction is, so long as they aren't being influenced by a Gu effect. When NPCs try to do the same to other NPCs, it's up to the GM whether or not the target is swayed.

Awarding Experience

There are two avenues of progression in this game: Experience and cultivation. Experience is used to purchase talents as well as increase Attributes and skills, while cultivation improves a player's raw power by increasing their pool of primeval essence and allowing the use of higher rank Gu. Experience is awarded for overcoming challenges such as by fighting beasts and other Gu Masters, but can also be awarded for engaging in intrigue. The amount of experience awarded should be reflective of the overall difficulty of the encounter, with an average of 8-12 experience per session.

Battle Strength

Combat encounters can be judged by the **Battle Strength** of all creatures in the encounter. The lowest **Battle Strength** a creature can have is 1, representing a common **Chaff** beast like an insect or bird. For the **Battle Strength** of beasts, see Chapter 5: Southern Border. The base **Battle Strength** for a Gu Master is {10, 100, 500, 5,000, 50,000}.

The base **Battle Strength** assumes the Gu Master has some Gu already of the previous rank, except of course for rank 1 Gu Masters. This base value is increased by 10% for every 100 maximum portions of primeval essence in their aperture. **Battle Strength** is then increased by however many Gu the Gu Master has of the same rank as themselves, with each Gu adding {50, 100, 250, 1,000, 20,000} to the total **Battle Strength**.

This number is not a perfect representation since Gu Masters might have higher statistics or advanced killer moves, but it gives a good idea of how strong a threat is compared to the players. If the **Battle Strength** of the threat is more than double the combined **Battle Strength** of the party, the encounter is considered deadly. If it is less than half, it is considered trivial.

Character Creation

In this game, you will create and play a Gu Master. Gu Masters are humans or variant-humans who have awakened their aperture, a kind of extradimensional space within the stomach that can contain Gu and primeval essence. The first thing to mark down is your starting rank. For first-time players, it is recommended to start at rank 1 initial stage. You, your group, and the game master should also determine if you want to follow the righteous path, living and working with a clan, or if you'd like to tread the demonic path, living free in the world with no masters. Your path can always be changed later on, as demonic Gu Masters seek safety and resources, and righteous Gu Masters grow disillusioned and yearn for freedom.

Once you know what each primary Attribute does, pick one as your Tagged Attribute. Whenever you spend experience to increase the tagged primary Attribute, you gain twice as many points as you normally would. Tagging your Fortitude Attribute grants you the **Tough Talent** for free.

Primary Attributes

Primary Attributes are a generalized measure of your body and mind. The base values of each of your skills are derived from these Attributes. All Attribute scores start at 20 before you spend any experience to improve them. Improving an Attribute also increases the value of all derived skills and secondary Attributes.

When you create your character, pick a primary Attribute as your tagged Attribute. Whenever you spend experience to increase that Attribute, you gain twice as many points as you normally would.

Agility - Agility is used to dodge attacks, fight in close quarters, and to maneuver in the air. Every 20 points of Agility increases your Movement and the number of *Reactions* you can take each turn by 1.

Fortitude - Fortitude determines your **Hit Points**, **Strength**, and is a major factor in your **Perseverance**.

Cognition - The speed at which you think and make decisions. Used to create killer moves, refinement recipes, and to fight in ranged combat. Every 20 points of Cognition increases the number of Gu you can activate each turn by 1.

Wisdom - Wisdom increases your speed of cultivation, how often you succeed when refining Gu, and awareness of your surroundings. Every 20 points of Wisdom increases the number of Gu you can activate each turn by 1.

Attitude - Attitude represents your understanding of human nature, relationships, and emotions. A higher attitude makes it easier to deceive and persuade others, and to know when others are deceiving you. It also is a minor factor in your Perseverance.

Secondary Attributes

Secondary Attributes either have a flat base value or are derived from your primary Attributes.

Health - You have a pool of Hit Points equal to your Fortitude. You can read about how damage, dying, and injury works in Chapter 4: Combat.

Movement - Your Movement is the number of meters you can move in a turn. Your Movement is 4 meters + 5% of your Agility (rounded down).

Strength - Your body's physical power. Strength is often overlooked by Gu Masters, as even rank 1 Gu can overpower the strongest of mortals. But battles are unpredictable, and when primeval essence runs dry

Gu Masters may resort to a fistfight. Though this statistic is more relevant at rank 1, some Gu Masters choose to use Gu to enhance their strength and rely on their own muscles to pound their enemies into meat paste. Your Strength score begins equal to your Fortitude and affects the amount of damage you deal with attacks where your physical strength is a factor.

If your Strength Attribute is ever reduced to 0, you immediately fall unconscious. If it remains 0 for a minute straight, you die.

Perseverance - Your Perseverance is your ability to endure great pain and stress, and is equal to the sum of your Fortitude and 1/2 of your Attitude, rounded down. Perseverance is rolled when you hit 0 Hit Points.

Soul - Your Soul score is a literal representation of the strength of your soul. Your starting Soul value is 6 + 20% of your Attitude, and if your current soul is ever less than half of its maximum (rounded down), you have the *fatigued* condition until your soul is restored to at least half strength. Refining Gu, cultivating, and controlling beast groups all drain the strength of your soul, while sleeping restores it. Many Soul Path Gu also use the strength of your soul to determine their strength when activated. If your current soul ever hits 0 points, you die. When you sleep, your soul recovers 10% of its maximum (rounded down) for every hour spent sleeping. Sleeping for at least 10 hours fully rejuvenates your soul, regardless of rounding.

Your base soul value is 6 + 20% of your Attitude, and represents the single-man soul. Many Soul Path Gu can strengthen your soul and increase this value. Whenever your soul takes 1/2 or more of its maximum value in soul damage (rounded down) on a single turn, roll 1d6 and reduce the maximum value of your soul by that amount.

When your soul reaches strength 100, you have the ten-man soul. It has the proper strength to sustain damage; you no longer lose maximum soul when you take more than 1/2 of your souls maximum in soul damage.

When your soul reaches strength 1,000, you have the hundred-man soul. If you have not refined your soul using Gu, this is the maximum strength achievable. If your soul increases in strength above 1009 without being refined, your soul explodes and you die, with resurrection being impossible.

When your soul reaches strength 10,000, you have the thousand-man soul. This is the limit for mortal Gu Masters and cannot be raised higher.

Luck - Players begin with 1 maximum luck point. Luck can be spent to force you or another creature to reroll a skill test directly after the roll, or to add a -50 bonus to a skill test you're making, before the roll. If you've expended a luck point on a skill test, you cannot spend another on the same skill test. You regain luck points up to your maximum at the start of each session.

Non-player characters do not usually have any luck points, but feel free to give tougher enemies one or even multiple if they're meant to be especially strong.

Activations - When you take the **Activate Gu Combat Action**, you can activate a number of Gu equal to your Activations. You have a number of Activations equal to 5% of (Cognition + Wisdom), rounding down to a

minimum of 1. To make this calculation easier, consider that for every 20 score you have in both Attributes, this number will increase by 1.

Shang Liu has a Cognition of 46 and a Wisdom of 37. With a total of 83 and every 20 combined score giving 1 Activation, brings his total Activations to 4.

Reactions - Reactions are a major factor in combat, and you can make up to 1 + 5% of your Agility (rounded down) Reactions each turn. Reactions can be used to dodge attacks, counterattack, and to activate certain Gu in response to an enemy's actions.

Aptitude - Your Gu Master's aptitude is incredibly important to their cultivation and battle strength. A higher aptitude means greater primeval essence, meaning your Gu Master can fight for longer and cultivate quicker. Aptitude is mostly immutable, but some Gu exist to raise or even lower a Gu Master's aptitude.

Choosing your Gu Master's aptitude is a decision that will significantly shape their journey. Higher aptitudes offer undeniable advantages in cultivation speed, primeval essence, and clan support, but they come with the heavy burdens of increased clan expectations, heightened scrutiny, and potential danger. Lower aptitudes, while slower in cultivation, afford your Gu Master greater freedom, fewer obligations, and opportunities to forge their own path.

It is also worth considering the other players in your group. If one player is an A-grade aptitude and another is D-grade, your ranks will most likely diverge dramatically in the early to mid stages. This difference is not insurmountable, but it may not be enjoyable for the weaker Gu Master. It's recommended for the group to decide on 2 adjacent grades and have each player pick one of the two.

Aptitude is just an arbitrary grading of the amount of primeval essence a Gu Master's aperture can store. After choosing your aptitude, roll a d20, subtract 1 from the result, and add it to the minimum essence percentage of your grade to determine your personal maximum primeval essence.

For example, Shang Liu chooses A-grade aptitude and rolls a 4 on his d20. Subtract 1 to get 3 and add that to the minimum of 80%. Shang Liu therefore has 83% as his maximum.

Grade - A: 80%-99% | **Grade - B:** 60%-79% | **Grade - C:** 40%-59% | **Grade - D:** 20%-39%

Experience

You start with 500 experience to spend on character creation. Any experience left over afterwards is removed from the game, so that you start your first session with 0 experience. Experience can be spent to increase your Attributes and Skills, as well as to purchase talents. Talents cannot be purchased and Attainments cannot be invested in until after character creation.

- 1 point in any Attribute costs 10 experience to increase up to 50, and 15 experience thereafter.
- 1 point in any skill (except Knowledge) costs 2 experience to increase.
- 5 points in Strength or any single Knowledge skill costs 6 experience.

Size and Fortitude

All creatures, objects, and Gu have a size. Humans start with a size that determines their minimum and maximum Fortitude, though both the minimum and maximum can be breached with the use of Gu. At character creation, pick either **[Small]**, **[Medium]**, or **[Large]**. If you pick **[Small]**, you begin with 10 Fortitude

and cannot raise it above 20 without the use of Gu. If you pick [Medium], you begin with 20 Fortitude and cannot raise it above 40. If you pick [Large], you begin with 40 Fortitude and cannot raise it above 100.

Size	Modifiers
Tiny	The size of an insect. Attack rolls against [Tiny] targets have a +40 penalty and [Tiny] creatures have their base Close Combat skill reduced by 20.
Small	The size of a child. Attack rolls against [Small] targets have a +20 penalty and [Small] creatures have their base Close Combat skill reduced by 10.
Medium	The size of a man. No modifiers.
Large	[Large] things take up 4 squares when outside of your aperture. Attack rolls against [Large] targets have a -20 bonus and [Large] creatures have their base Close Combat skill increased by 10.
Huge	[Huge] things take up 9 or more squares when outside of an aperture. Attack rolls against [Huge] targets have a -40 bonus and [Huge] creatures have their base Close Combat skill increased by 40.

Attainment

Attainment is your understanding of the different Gu paths. That includes your knowledge of refining, using, and identifying Gu of the same path. You can find the different Attainments in the Talents section (Chapter 2. Progression), and your character begins the game with 50 free experience invested in a single path.

Starting Items

All characters start with a Gu Master robe, a Vital Gu of rank 1, and 25 primeval stones. At the GM's discretion (for price and availability) you may trade your starting primeval stones for additional rank 1 Gu.

Lifespan

If your character reaches age 100 without increasing their lifespan, they die.

Starting At Higher Ranks

If a character dies during the course of play, or if your group just wants to start at a higher rank, you can start at a higher rank and stage than rank 1 initial stage. At initial stage of any rank, you begin with a single Gu of the same rank as you and 4 Gu of the rank immediately below you. For every small realm above initial stage, you gain 1 additional Gu of the same rank as you.

In addition, you start with {25, 250, 2,500, 25,000, 250,000} primeval stones depending on rank and an additional 150 character-creation experience for every rank above 1. Finally, you gain 100 talent experience for every rank above 1 that you start at; this experience can only be spent on talents or invested in attainments and is removed when you finish creating your character just like the ordinary starting experience.

Finding a Build

Since Gu have to be fed, it can be financially draining to have a large collection covering every possible

situation. Until they have a steady source of income, most Gu Masters just try to cover attack, defense, healing, and movement with their Gu, and perhaps a few for utility. It is of course possible to rely on your teammates for one or more of those categories, but it's worth noting that support Gu that only affect yourself are usually more potent than those that target others.

Skills

Your character's Skills represent their learned abilities and proficiencies, whether that be in combat, dialogue, or cultivation. The base value of the skill is dependent on what Attribute(s) it is derived from, shown in the parenthesis. Remember to increase your skill values whenever you purchase points in the corresponding Attribute.

Close Combat (Agility)

Close Combat does not only include fighting hand-to-hand, it relates to any fighting that occurs within 2 meters of you. Your attack rolls made against targets within 2 meters of you are made with the **Close Combat** skill. Melee attacks are always made with your **Close Combat** skill.

Ranged Attack (Cog)

If an enemy is 3 or more meters from you, your non-melee attack rolls are made with the **Ranged Attack** skill.

Athletics (1/2 Str + 1/2 Agi)

Athletics is used for strength related actions such as pushing a boulder, climbing a steep cliff, or swimming.

Pushing and Pulling

You can push or pull any weight under 100kg without making a test, halving your movement (rounded down) if the weight is over 50kg. Above 100kg you must make an **Athletics** skill test with a -40 bonus, increased by +10 for every 50kg over 100.

Dodge (Agi)

Dodge is used as a **Reaction** to avoid attacks made against you, either melee or ranged.

When you succeed a **Dodge** skill test, you MUST move at least 1 meter and at most 1/2 your movement (rounded down) in any direction.

Flying (Agi)

A Gu Master may live his entire life without taking to the skies, but to those that do, this skill is a necessity. Without a decent **Flying** skill, a Gu Master can be easier to hit in the air than they would be on the ground.

Refinement (Wis)

Even with a complete recipe, refining Gu is an arduous process, requiring precision and constant vigilance. When refinement fails it triggers a backlash which can hurt or even kill you and your Gu. Your **Refinement** skill determines how complex of recipes you can follow, and how often your refinement fails.

Deduction (Cog)

Deduction is used to create and refine Gu recipes as well as to develop killer moves; the combination of multiple Gu used simultaneously to deliver a very potent effect. It can also be used to investigate your surroundings for clues.

Some Gu have the [**Deductive**] keyword. When activated, these Gu unlock a special **Deduction** action. To take it, you must spend an hour deducing a specific subject and make a **Deduction** skill test. Penalties and Bonuses are determined by the amount of supporting information available to you. The subject can be something that occurred in the past, such as who might have committed a murder, or something happening in the present or future, like why a rival clan purchased a huge amount of an unusual refinement material. Deductions cannot create information out of thin air, and a success does not necessarily mean your deduction is correct if you lack a key piece of evidence. For every degree of success on the check, however, you gain one additional conclusion about the subject.

Persuasion (Att)

Persuasion can only be used on non-player characters. **Persuasion** skill tests are used to sway a character through rhetoric and empathy.

Deception (Att)

Deception can only be used on non-player characters. Your ability to manipulate and deceive others.

Intimidation (Att)

Intimidation can only be used on non-player characters.

Haggle (Att)

Haggle can only be used on non-player characters. Prices are reduced by 5% for every 20 points you have in your **Haggle** skill. Additionally, you can make **Haggle** skill tests to attempt sway a creature with a deal or bargain.

Insight (Wis)

Used to judge a character's body language and intonation. A successful **Insight** test involves learning a character's intention and scrutinizing their body language, and in most cases will not straight up say whether a character is lying or not.

Awareness (Wis)

Your ability to notice things in the environment. If you're meticulously searching an area, use **Deduction**, but to notice an out of place detail while walking past a building you would use **Awareness**.

When you do something sneaky in front of someone, such as trying to steal something out of their pockets, they make an **Awareness** skill test, noticing you on a success. Creatures can only make **Awareness** skill tests to notice a creature if they are able to sense them; If an *invisible* creature tries to sneak up behind you, you could still make an **Awareness** skill test as long as the creature is making sound. If they're walking on a creaky floorboard, you could have a -40 bonus, but on soft soil it could be as bad as a +40 penalty. If an *inaudible* creature was sneaking up behind you though, you would not have an opportunity to make the **Awareness** skill test since you can't see or hear them. **Awareness** does include smell, but you can only make a smell-based **Awareness** skill test to detect a creature if the target is very smelly or if your sense of smell is augmented to be stronger.

Succeeding an **Awareness** skill test to detect an *invisible* creature only informs you of their presence; you are aware another creature is present and know their general direction, but not their exact square.

Cultivation (Wis)

The higher your **Cultivation** skill, the less damage you will take to your soul during cultivation, and the quicker your cultivation will increase.

Knowledge (Cog)

Knowledge is separated into a few categories:

- Gu - There are an uncountable number of different Gu in the world, and this skill helps to identify them. In a fight, it can mean life or death.
- Southern Border - Your understanding of the geography, flora, and fauna of Southern Border. It can be assumed that all characters will have knowledge of the areas surrounding their clan, but when journeying beyond familiarity this skill can be used to identify beasts, plants, and natural formations.
- Clans - Small, medium, large, and super-sized clans dot the mountains and valleys of Southern Border. This skill represents your knowledge of their names, power structures, specialties, and commerce.

Chapter 2 - Progression

Cultivating

The process of increasing your rank in small and large realms is called cultivating. To cultivate, you must meditate and will the primeval essence in your aperture to attack and weaken the aperture walls.

Small Realms

When you're attempting to break through a small realm, the walls retain any damage done by your primeval essence; thus you can slowly break through over time.

For every 2 sequential hours that you spend cultivating, make a **Cultivation** skill test. You bank a number of hours according to the *Aptitude vs Hours Banked* table whether or not you succeed, but on a failure, you take damage to your soul equal to the number of degrees of failure on the test, with fumbles counting as an additional degree of failure. On a critical success, you bank an additional hour of cultivation.

When your banked hours reach the number you need to break through to the next realm, you lose all banked hours and your rank increases by a small realm. When you successfully break through a small realm, your maximum portions of primeval essence is doubled but you retain your current number of portions.

Aptitude	Hours Banked
Extreme Physique	5
A	4
B	3
C	2
D	1

Target Realm	Aperture Wall	Banked Hours Needed
Middle	Light Membrane	100
Upper	Water Membrane	200
Peak	Stone Membrane	400

Breaking Through to the Next Rank

When you reach peak stage of a rank, the aperture wall becomes a crystal membrane and the walls gain the ability to naturally recover over a short time, making it necessary to break the walls in a single sitting. This takes a number of hours according to the following table:

<i>Aptitude vs Target Rank</i>	2	3	4	5
Extreme Physique	8	16	24	32
A-Grade	16	24	32	40
B-Grade	24	32	40	-
C-Grade	32	40	-	-
D-Grade	40	-	-	-

If your Aptitude is too low to break through to the next rank, you must either increase your Aptitude to a higher grade or consume primeval stones to make up for the difference.

Talents

Taking any breaks from the process gives your aperture time to fully heal, meaning you need to restart from the beginning. Every 2 hours you spend cultivating to break through a large realm, make a Cultivation skill test. On a failure, you take damage to your soul equal to the number of degrees of failure on the test. On a fumble, you take an additional point of damage to your soul.

Whether you are breaking through a large realm or a small realm, all **Cultivation** skill tests are made with a penalty or bonus according to the following table:

Target Rank	Modifier
1	-40
2	-20
3	none
4	+20
5	+40

When you break through a large realm, your primeval sea is completely emptied of the previous rank's primeval essence and your maximum primeval essence is reset to your aptitude.

Consuming Primeval Stones

You can expend primeval stones to hasten your cultivation, and you may do so to assist in breaking through both small and large realms. Every 2 sequential hours spent cultivating to break through a small realm, you can expend {10, 100, 1,000, 10,000, 100,000} primeval stones. If you do so, you bank 5 additional hours.

For every {10, 100, 1,000, 10,000, N/A} primeval stones you expend when cultivating to break through to the next rank, it takes 1 less hour of cultivation.

If your Aptitude is too low to break through to the next rank, you can consume {100, 1,000, 10,000, 100,000, 1,000,000} primeval stones to consider your Aptitude 1 grade higher during this cultivation session. You may do this multiple times.

If your cultivation is interrupted, divide the number of primeval stones that would have been expended had you been successful by the total

number of hours you would have cultivated to find how many stones you consumed each hour. Multiply that figure by the number of hours your cultivated before being interrupted to find how many stones you expended.

Spending Experience

In addition to progressing through cultivation, you also get more skilled as a Gu Master as time passes. The GM will award experience at the end of each session, recommended to be between 8-12 experience. Experience earned in this way can be used in a number of ways. At the GM's discretion, the players will be allowed to spend their accrued experience at a particular time. Typical situations to allow spending of experience are either when the party is safe and able to rest, or whenever they increase their cultivation.

Downtime

Gu Masters have many different activities available to them during downtime. Cultivation is described in this chapter, but you can also spend time creating refinement recipes for Gu, improving refinement recipes, actually refining Gu, deducing killer moves, or studying and practicing. Details on refinement recipes and killer moves are given in Chapter 3: Gu.

Studying

To study, you must first acquire a teacher or their recorded instructional material such as a book or Information Path Gu. Your progress is quickened or slowed depending on the quality of your teacher or reading material.

For every 8 hours spent learning with a tutor, you invest 2, 5, or 12 experience, depending on if the teacher has *Fundamental*, *Intermediate*, or *Master* Attainment (respectively) in the path you are trying to learn. You cannot increase your Attainment in this way beyond the threshold of your teacher's Attainment level.

Skilled tutors are available for hire in most mid to large-sized clans; Those with *Fundamental* Attainment

charge around 50 primeval stones, while those with *Intermediate* Attainment charge around 200 primeval stones per 8 hour session. Masters of a path are difficult to find, often being highly ranked or very old lone cultivators. Many are in charge of entire forces, and unwilling to teach for mere primeval stones if anything at all. If you do find a master willing to teach you, they will often ask for a favor in return.

When learning a path from recorded material, the experience gained is halved (to a minimum of 1), and is dependent on the Attainment of the author when it was created.

Learning Talents

You can also learn Talents from others as long as they have purchased the Talent and you fulfill any requirements for it. For every 4 hours you spend being instructed, you gain 5 experience that can only be used to purchase the Talent being learned. You must be personally instructed to learn Talents and cannot learn them from books and other recorded material. You can learn Talents and Refinement Techniques in this way, but not Path Attainments.

Instructing Others

Personally instructing others can be fulfilling and a good learning experience. You gain 1 experience every 8 hour session spent teaching an Attainment. When you successfully teach someone else a Talent, you gain 2 experience.

Agile Strikes

Cost: 20 experience

Requires Fundamental Wind Path Attainment

Whenever you add your Strength Attribute to the damage of an attack, you may instead use your **Athletics** skill.

Bow Training

Cost: 10 experience

You can use bows with a draw weight 40 kilograms higher than you would normally be able to.

Charger

Cost: 20 experience

When you take the *Sprint* **Combat Action**, you may make a single punch attack or activate a Gu with a range of *Touch* at some point during your turn. If you make a punch attack and it hits, the target is thrown backward 1 meter for every 100 points you have in Strength. Making the attack or activating a Gu with a range of *Touch* expends the remainder of your movement.

Combat Absorption

Cost: 30 experience

You can multitask on absorbing primeval stones in the heat of combat. You may absorb the essence of primeval stones as a **Bonus Action** or a **Combat Action**.

Charlatan

Cost: 60 experience

Your Attitude Attribute is permanently increased by 5 and you gain advantage on **Deception** skill tests.

Dagger Training

Cost: 15 experience

You score a critical hit on Close Combat skill tests made with daggers if the number on the die is 20% of your Close Combat skill or less.

Flurry

Cost: 20 experience

Requires Fundamental Strength Path Attainment

You gain access to the **Flurry Combat Action**.

Flurry: For every arm you have, make two punch attacks against a creature within 1 meter. You gain a +20 penalty to **Dodge** skill tests and **Close Combat** skill tests made to parry attacks until the start of your next turn.

Cultivation Practice

Cost: 30 experience

Your **Cultivation** skill is permanently increased by 10. Reduce any damage dealt to your soul when you fail a **Cultivation** skill test by 1.

Flying Master

Cost: 45 experience

Taking flight no longer expends one of your Maneuvers per turn. Your **Flying** skill is permanently increased by 20.

Glib

Cost: 70 experience

Your Attitude Attribute is permanently increased by 5. You gain advantage on **Haggle** and **Persuasion** skill tests.

Lightning Reflexes

Cost: 10 experience

Requires Master Lightning Path Attainment

Your **Dodge** skill is permanently increased by 10 and you gain advantage on initiative rolls. You gain an additional *Reaction* each turn.

Martial Artist

Cost: 15 experience

Can be purchased up to 3 times

You gain a -5 bonus to **Close Combat** and **Dodge** skill tests while not wielding any weapons.

Multitasker

Cost: 40 experience

Can be purchased up to 3 times

You can sustain an additional Gu every turn without incurring damage to your soul.

Multi-Weapon Fighting

Cost: 20 experience

You can make a number of melee attacks as part of a melee attack **Combat Action** as you have wielded weapons, with a +10 penalty to each attack. When wielding only 2 weapons, this penalty is removed.

Natural Muscle Training

Cost: 15 experience

Can be purchased up to 5 times

Your Strength Attribute is permanently increased by 9 and your Fortitude Attribute is permanently increased by 1.

Since Strength is derived from Fortitude, your Strength increases by a total of 10

Not So Fast

Cost: 25 experience

You may make the *Grapple* **Combat Action** as an attack of opportunity. You still have disadvantage on the **Close Combat** skill test if the target triggered your attack of opportunity with a **Dodge** skill test.

Pain Tolerance

Cost: 10 experience

Requires Intermediate Strength Path Attainment

Can be purchased up to 3 times

Cannot be learned through downtime

Your maximum hit points are increased by 5, and you gain a -10 bonus to all **Perseverance** Attribute tests.

Partial Artist

Cost: 80 experience

You've had an epiphany and internalized the idea of Painting Path. Choose a single Gu with the **[Dao]** keyword (whether you own it or not). You may be under the effects of that Gu even if its path is not compatible with the paths of your other **[Dao]** Gu. Whenever you break through a small or large realm, you may replace your chosen Gu with a different one.

[Path] Scholar

Cost: 10 experience

Requires Fundamental [Path] Attainment

You gain a -20 bonus to **Knowledge (Gu)** skill tests made to identify [Path] Gu.

Pickpocket

Cost: 10 experience

Requires Fundamental Theft Path Attainment

Awareness skill tests made to detect you stealing from someone's pockets are made with disadvantage

Poison Resistant

Cost: 20 experience

Requires Intermediate Poison Path Attainment

The duration of poisons affecting you are reduced by half, rounded down to a minimum of 1 turn.

Your **Fortitude** is permanently increased by 5.

Reactive Flight

Cost: 15 experience

As a **Reaction** to being sent *airborne*, you can activate a Gu that grants a flying speed and immediately execute a Maneuver for free.

Sentinel

Cost: 25 experience

Whenever a creature within your melee range makes a melee attack against your ally, you may use the **Parry Reaction** against it. You gain a -10 bonus to all **Close Combat** skill tests made as part of the **Parry Reaction** (including the follow-up attack).

Shoal Skirter

Cost: 10 experience

Requires Fundamental Water Path Attainment

You move twice as fast in water and you can hold your breath twice as long as you would normally be able to..

Skulker

Cost: 15 experience

Requires Fundamental Dark Path Attainment

Awareness skill tests made to perceive you are made with a +20 penalty.

Spear Training

Cost: 20 experience

Can be purchased twice

While wielding a single spear and no other weapons, you may make an additional attack with a spear whenever you take the **Melee Attack Combat Action** to attack with a spear, so long as you use a different number of hands than the last time you attacked this turn (2 handed -> 1 handed, or vice versa). This additional attack can be made at any point during your turn.

Staff Training

Cost: 20 experience

Can be purchased twice

You gain advantage on Close Combat skill tests made to block an attack while wielding a staff. Additionally, you gain a -20 bonus to and deal 3 additional force damage on called shot attack rolls made with a staff.

Sword Training

Cost: 5 experience

Requires Fundamental Sword Path Attainment

Can be purchased twice if you have Intermediate Sword Path Attainment, and up to 3 times if you have Master Sword Path Attainment

You may make an additional attack with a sword whenever you take the **Melee Attack Combat Action** to attack with a sword. This additional attack can be made at any point during your turn, and does not count towards your total attacks when Multi-weapon Fighting. Additionally, you gain a -20 bonus to **Close Combat** skill tests made to parry an attack while wielding a sword.

Tough

Cost: 60 experience

Cannot be learned through downtime

Your base hit points are equal to twice your Fortitude.

Twice as Bright, Twice as Fast

Cost: 20 experience

Requires Fundamental Fire Path Attainment

Once per turn, when you activate a Fire Path Gu of the same rank as you, you may expend twice its primeval essence cost to activate a Fire Path Gu of a lower rank than you for free, without spending an activation.

Well Fed

Cost: 20 experience

Requires Fundamental Food Path Attainment

Can be purchased up to 3 times

Cannot be learned through downtime

Your Fortitude is permanently increased by 5, your weight is increased by 25 kilograms, and your movement is reduced by 1. If you purchase this talent 3 times, your size becomes [Large].

Wrestling Techniques

Cost: 20 Experience

Requires Fundamental Strength Path Attainment

You gain a -10 bonus to **Athletics** skill tests resulting from a *Grapple* **Combat Action**. When you successfully grapple a creature, you may make a single punch attack against them as part of the *Grapple* **Combat Action**.

Refinement Techniques

Refinement techniques are used to improve the Gu refinement process in many different ways, such as reducing the difficulty, duration, or even material cost of a refinement recipe. Only one refinement technique can be used on a recipe at a time.

Batch Refinement

Cost: 25 experience

Requires Intermediate Refinement Path Attainment

You gain access to the Batch Refinement refinement technique. When you use the Batch Refinement refinement technique, you gain a +20 penalty to **Refinement** skill tests, and every cost of the recipe is tripled (including Gu). If you succeed the **Refinement** skill test, you produce 5 of the Gu; you must roll the failure die separately for each Gu.

Bellows Stove

Cost: 15 experience

Requires Fundamental Wind Path Attainment

You gain access to the Bellows Stove refinement technique. When you use the Bellows Stove refinement technique, you gain a -20 bonus to **Refinement** skill tests. If you fail the refinement, the damage of the backlash is increased by 2. This refinement technique can only be used to refine Fire, Food, and Wind Path Gu.

Brute Force

Cost: 25 experience

Requires Master Strength Path Attainment

You gain access to the Brute Force refinement technique. When you use the Brute Force refinement technique, you gain a -40 bonus to **Refinement** skill tests, and the failure die of the recipe is forced to be a d2. If the recipe belongs to Strength Path, the failure die is instead a d3. This refinement technique cannot be used to refine Wisdom Path Gu.

Dice Falling Waterfall

Cost: 10 experience

Requires Fundamental Luck Path Attainment

You gain access to the Dice Falling Waterfall refinement technique. When you use the Dice Falling Waterfall refinement technique, you must roll the failure die twice and take the lower result. Upon successfully refining a Gu with this technique, you gain a luck point. This refinement technique cannot be used to refine Rule Path Gu.

Dual Refinement

Cost: 20 experience

Requires Intermediate Refinement Path Attainment

You gain access to the Dual Refinement refinement technique. When you use the Dual Refinement refinement technique, you may refine two unique Gu at the same time. The Gu must be of the same or compatible paths (see Ch. 3, Gu) and their recipes must have the same duration. You make only one **Refinement** test, but otherwise treat the refinement as if they were two separate refinements.

Extended Refinement

Cost: 10 experience

Requires Fundamental Refinement Path Attainment

You gain access to the Extended Refinement refinement technique. When you use the Extended Refinement refinement technique, you gain a -20 bonus to **Refinement** skill tests, and the duration of the recipe is increased by 8 hours. This refinement technique cannot be used to refine Time Path Gu.

False Refinement

False refinement was invented by Thieving Heaven Demon Venerable, enabling the production of counterfeit Gu.

Cost: 20 experience

Requires Intermediate Refinement Path Attainment

You gain access to the False Refinement refinement technique. When you use the False Refinement refinement technique, you gain a -10 bonus to **Refinement** skill tests, and the primeval stone cost of the recipe is reduced by 75% (rounded down). When you successfully refine a Gu using the False Refinement refinement technique, the refined Gu is *counterfeit*. It cannot be activated, but otherwise appears exactly the same as the real version of the Gu. Gu used to appraise the counterfeit must be of a rank equal to or higher than your degrees of success (maximum 5) on the **Refinement** skill test in order to determine it is a fake.

Hairy Man Heaven and Earth

Condenses Gu from Heaven and Earth, opposed to Human Isolation Style. This technique is normally known only to Hairy Men, and takes great practice to perform.

Cost: 50 experience

Requires Master Refinement Path Attainment

You gain access to the Hairy Man Heaven and Earth refinement technique. When you use the Hairy Man Heaven and Earth refinement technique, you gain a -30 bonus to **Refinement** skill tests, and the failure die of the recipe is increased by 2 stages (d4 -> d8, d6 -> d10...). This refinement technique cannot be used to refine Human Path Gu.

One After Another

Cost: 25 experience

Requires Fundamental Wood Path Attainment

You gain access to the One After Another refinement technique. When you use the One After Another refinement technique, you gain a -30 bonus to **Refinement** skill tests, and the duration of the refinement is increased by 4 hours. This refinement technique can only be used to refine Wood Path Gu.

Reduction

Cost: 20 experience

Requires Intermediate Food Path Attainment

You gain access to the Reduction refinement technique. When you use the Reduction refinement technique, the primeval stone cost of the recipe is reduced by 50% (rounded down). If you fail the refinement, the damage of the backlash is reduced by 1.

Research

Cost: 25 experience

Requires Intermediate Wisdom Path Attainment

You gain access to the Research refinement technique. Whenever you successfully refine a Gu using the Research refinement technique, you gain a -20 bonus on your next **Refinement** test made to improve that recipe. This bonus does not stack.

Sacrifice

Cost: 10 experience

Requires Intermediate Blood Path Attainment

You gain access to the Sacrifice refinement technique. Whenever you use the Sacrifice refinement technique, you may take any amount of damage directly to your hit points. This damage cannot be reduced or negated in any way. The primeval stone cost of the recipe is reduced by $100 * (\text{sacrificed hit points})$, to a minimum of 10% of the recipe's primeval stone cost.

Sauté

Cost: 15 experience

Requires Fundamental Food Path Attainment

You gain access to the Sauté refinement technique. When you use the Sauté refinement technique, you gain a -10 bonus to all **Refinement** tests, and increase the primeval stone cost of the recipe by 50%

(rounding down). For every Gu used in the recipe, roll 1d10. If you roll a 1, that Gu is not consumed during the refinement.

Shower

Cost: 15 experience

Requires Fundamental Water Path Attainment

You gain access to the Shower refinement technique. When you use the Shower refinement technique, you gain a -10 bonus to **Refinement** skill tests, and the duration of the recipe is reduced by 50%. This refinement technique can only be used to refine Blood, Poison, and Water Path Gu.

Starfall

Cost: 15 experience

Requires Fundamental Fire Path Attainment

You gain access to the Starfall refinement technique. When you use the Starfall refinement technique, you gain a -10 bonus to **Refinement** skill tests, increased to -20 when refining Fire Path Gu. This refinement technique can only be used to refine Fire, Light, Lightning, and Space Path Gu.

Yin Yang

Cost: 20 experience

You gain access to the Yin Yang refinement technique. When you use the Yin Yang refinement technique, you may refine two unique Gu at the same time. Their recipes must have the same duration, and the paths of the Gu must be one of the following pairs:

- Fire and Ice Path
- Space and Time Path
- Strength and Wisdom Path
- Light and Dark Path
- Earth and Wind Path
- Luck and Information Path

You make only one **Refinement** test, but otherwise treat the refinement as if they were two separate refinements.

Attainment

It's difficult to use and improve Gu of a path you aren't familiar with. Oftentimes, a Gu Master that achieves Master Attainment in any path gains fame for their accomplishment, and may be contacted by other forces to refine Gu or complete difficult tasks related to the path.

Attainment in each path is tracked on your character sheet by the amount of experience invested in it. Whenever you can spend experience to purchase talents or improve your Attributes and skills, you may choose to invest experience in specific paths. When you reach the threshold of invested experience in a path, you gain the Attainment as if it were a Talent. This means once you have invested 250 total experience in a path, you will have *Fundamental*, *Intermediate*, and *Master* Attainment in that path. You can also gain experience in a path by creating and improving recipes, deducing killer moves, and refining Gu that belong to that path. Every character starts with 50 free experience invested in a single path.

[Path] Attainment

Fundamental

Threshold: 50 experience

You become familiar with the core teachings of [Path], and you gain the following benefits:

- You gain a -20 bonus to all Refinement and Knowledge (Gu) skill tests to refine or identify [Path] Gu.
- You gain a -20 bonus to Refinement skill tests made to improve or create refinement recipes for [Path] Gu.
- You can improve refinement recipes for [Path] Gu.
- You can deduce killer moves whose core Gu includes [Path] Gu.

Intermediate

Threshold: 120 experience

Your understanding of [Path] has reached a qualitative change, and you gain the following benefits:

- You gain an additional **Bonus Action** that can only be used to activate a single [Path] Gu on your turn
- You gain a -20 bonus to all **Refinement** and **Knowledge (Gu)** skill tests to refine or identify [Path] Gu.
- You gain a -20 bonus to **Refinement** skill tests made to improve or create refinement recipes for [Path] Gu.
- You gain a -10 bonus on **Deduction** skill tests made to deduce killer moves if they have a [Path] Gu in its core.
- You can create refinement recipes for [Path] Gu.

Master

Threshold: 250 experience

Your understanding of [Path] reaches the apex of mortal comprehension. You gain the following benefits:

- You gain a -40 bonus to all **Refinement** and **Knowledge (Gu)** skill tests to refine or identify [Path] Gu.

- You gain a -40 bonus to **Refinement** skill tests made to improve or create refinement recipes for [Path] Gu.
- You gain a -20 bonus on **Deduction** skill tests made to deduce killer moves if they have a [Path] Gu in its core.

Chapter 3 - Gu

Humans are the spirit of all living beings and Gu are the essence of Heaven and Earth. Mortal Gu represent fragments of the great Dao, or laws of Heaven, and are ranked from 1 to 5, just like mortal Gu Masters. Gu come in many different forms, with bugs being a common motif, but there are just as many that take the forms of beasts and objects. Gu can be either wild or refined; wild Gu usually refers to those birthed from natural primeval essence. These can come into being in any manner of places as long as the conditions are right. Sometimes they are carried by beasts, or roaming the earth alone, or staying sedentary in the place they were born. Refined Gu are those under the direct control of a Gu Master. They obey the user's commands without fail, even destroying themselves with a single thought. The Gu Master can acquire refined Gu by refining wild Gu, creating them themselves using their Refinement skill, or acquiring them from others. Refined Gu may become wild Gu if their master is killed, but this process takes some time.

Gu are separated into different categories based on the effect created when they are activated. These categories have minimal mechanical importance but give a good idea of the Gu's purpose.

Attack - Shooting a blade, controlling someone's mind, or softening a person's bones are all attacks. If the primary use of the Gu is to kill or apply negative effects to a person against their will, it is an attack.

Manifestation - Creates an object under the user's control. Can be permanent or temporary.

Guard - Forms a defensive barrier with the primary focus being blocking attacks.

Celerity - Enhances speed or maneuverability.

Divination - Gathers information, whether from a short distance or across the continent. Investigative Gu that increase a user's perception are included, as well as those that surveil areas, probe into people's minds, or improve your deduction skills.

Concealment - Hides the user's presence in any number of ways.

Tonic - Gu with a restorative effect. There exist tonic Gu for humans, beasts, and even other Gu.

Container - If objects can be placed inside, the Gu is typically a container. They can store objects, gu, and sometimes even people. Convenient for storing items and resources safely within your aperture.

Catalyst - A catch-all category for Gu that can be used to supplement other Gu and actions. Gu that increase the likelihood of refinement success, improve cultivation speed, or amplify the effects of other Gu are all catalysts.

Carver - Carves dao semi-permanently into the recipient. The most common carvers belong to strength and information path, used to increase a user's strength and create binding agreements, respectively.

Below is a sample statblock for the rank 1 *Moonlight Gu*. This is the signature Gu of the Gu Yue clan, and cannot be found anywhere else in Southern Border.

Moonlight Gu

Rank 1 Attack (This signifies that the Gu is of Rank 1, and is an Attack-type Gu)

Cost: 5 portions (*This Gu costs 5 portions to activate for a rank 1 Gu Master. Rank 2 and above Gu Masters instead only spend 1 portion*)

Range: 10 meters

Health: 10 (*This Gu has 10 health. If it hits 0, it dies*)

Food: Moon orchid petals (3 primeval stones) (*This gu eats moon orchid petals. Since it is a rank 1 Gu, it eats at the end of every session. When you have access to a market, you can substitute the materials with 3 primeval stones.*)

Effect: You hurl a flat, crescent-shaped beam of light. Make an attack roll with a -10 bonus. On a hit, deal 6 rending damage.

Vital Gu

The first Gu you refine gains the **[Vital]** keyword and becomes your Vital Gu. Yours and your Vital Gu's lifeforces are connected, and if your Vital Gu should die, you would as well. The Vital Gu has a major advantage, however; It cannot die due to backlash during refinement, instead dropping to 1 hp and being unusable in refinement until its hit points are restored to their maximum. This makes your Vital Gu a very important choice for progression, as you can attempt to refine it to a higher rank many times without worrying about its death.

To change your Vital Gu, you must spend a day in closed cultivation with the new Gu. When you change your Vital Gu, your current hit points are reduced to 1 as you suffer backlash. Your Vital Gu can be of any rank.

Rank

Mortal Gu have a rank of 1-5. Some Gu exist only at a single rank, others are found at several ranks, and others can only be raised in rank through refinement. For example, the rank 1 Dog Enslavement Gu can enslave a single dog. Rank 2 dog enslavement Gu can enslave a Hundred Beast King dog, rank 3 can enslave a Thousand Beast King dog, and so on, with each being found on increasingly strong dogs. The higher the rank of the Gu, the rarer it is, and their strength increases exponentially.

Gu above rank 5 are called Immortal Gu. Most can only be activated with Immortal Essence, though a few have other costs that can be paid by mortals. Forgetting mortal Gu Masters, even Rank 6 Gu Masters may live their entire life without owning an Immortal Gu. Each one is unique, and for however long it exists in the world, nobody else can refine a copy. When one appears, many Gu Immortals will fight to the death to get their hands on it, and when they fight, many tens of thousands of mortals can and do die in the crossfire.

Series

Some Gu belong to a series that spans multiple ranks. Some have additional effects based on their rank and will be listed separately. Others just scale up in numbers and will be under the same listing. If several values are inside curly braces, they represent the value at different ranks. If a Gu exists at ranks 3-5 and creates {1, 10, 100} fireballs, then it creates 1 fireball at rank 3, 10 at rank 4, and 100 at rank 5.

Price

Price is largely dependent on the rank of the Gu in question, but the market also needs to be considered. Relic Gu, for example, are quite rare and of an enormous help to a Gu Master's cultivation, which makes them more expensive than other Gu of the same rank. Beast Strength Gu, on the other hand, are almost always sold after use, keeping the supply higher and price lower than other Gu of the same rank. Generally, the prices below work for most Gu. If the Gu has the **[Expendable]** keyword, it is generally half the normal price, though some Gu with extraordinary effects like Relic Gu will be more expensive than even non-expendable Gu of the same rank.

Rank	Price
1	100
2	500
3	5,000
4	50,000
5	1,000,000+

Rank 4 and rank 5 Gu are significantly rarer than Gu of rank 1 to 3. It may be difficult to find a seller, and you may even encounter schemes and resistances from your opposition when trying to buy them.

Primeval Essence Costs

Gu statblocks will have a number of portions it costs to activate. This assumes you are of the same rank as the Gu. If your rank is lower than the Gu, your primeval essence is too weak, and the Gu costs 4 times as many portions to activate for every rank above you the Gu is. If you are Rank 2 and try to activate a Rank 4 Gu that costs 10 portions, instead it will cost you 160 portions. If the Gu is below your rank, it only costs a single portion of your primeval essence to activate.

Wild Gu

Wild Gu are found in the wilderness, typically in an environment rich with Dao of the Gu's path. Wild Gu have a speed of 8 meters (except **[Steed]** Gu with their own movement statistic) and will attempt to evade capture, including by activating themselves using natural primeval essence. Wild Gu can see through *concealments* of a lower rank than itself, and have an **Awareness** skill of $20 * \text{rank}$.

Refining Gu

Refining Gu can refer to two processes; the first is turning a wild Gu or a Gu refined by someone else into your own. The second is the act of following a recipe to create a new Gu. You cannot activate a Gu that is wild or belongs to someone else, unless the owner is willing. When a Gu you have refined is killed or refined by someone else, you immediately feel the connection between you get severed (but don't gain information on whether it was killed or refined).

Refining Existing Gu

When refining a wild Gu, the Gu must be subdued first. For smaller Gu this usually just involves catching it, but larger or more aggressive Gu may require you to weaken it in battle or through other means.

If the Gu is owned by someone else, they can weaken their will to allow you to refine the Gu for free. Otherwise, your will is pit against theirs. Make an opposed Wisdom Attribute test against the owner of the

Gu Keywords

Gu, with the higher ranked Gu Master gaining a -30 bonus for each rank they are above their opponent. If you win the test, the owner's will is driven out and you gain ownership of the Gu. If you lose, they retain control of the Gu, you take 1d4 damage to your soul, and you gain a stacking -10 bonus on subsequent rolls made to refine the Gu.

Once a wild Gu is subdued, you must be touching it to refine it into your own. To do so, you must spend 50 portions of primeval essence. If the Gu is of a higher rank than you, it costs 4 times as many portions to refine for each rank above you.

If the Gu is below your rank, it costs a single portion of primeval essence to refine.

If you do not have enough primeval essence to do so in one sitting, you may have to refine the Gu for a longer period, using your natural recovery and/or primeval stones to supply the rest of the required portions. Taking a break from the refinement causes it to fail, and the primeval essence used in the process is lost.

Feeding Gu

Gu are living beings and need to be fed. What they eat is determined by the Gu, while how often they eat is determined by the rank. Some Gu will have a number of primeval stones in parenthesis next to their food. If you have access to a market, you can spend that number of primeval stones for a feeding. Gu also cannot be fed during combat.

Rank	Interval
1	1 Session
2	2 Sessions
3	3 Sessions
4	5 Sessions
5	10 Sessions

If the food does not have a primeval stone cost next to it, that does not mean it is impossible to purchase, just that it is a rarer material. You can find your own out in the Southern Border, or seek out a seller of rare items.

To track food, mark the Gu's feeding interval in sessions inside the "Feeding Interval" column on your Gu sheet. At the end of every session, expend the cost of feeding each Gu or else subtract 1 from its feeding interval. When the Gu eats, set it back to the original feeding interval. If the feeding interval hits -1, the Gu starves to death. You can also feed a Gu outside of combat to restore its health whenever you wish, as long as you have the materials.

Detonating Gu

As a **Reaction** or for free at any time during their turn, a Gu Master can self-detonate any Gu owned and refined by them with a single thought. The Gu Master must be conscious to do so, and can detonate as many or as few Gu as they want, from any distance. If the Gu is being suppressed, such as by the land spirit of a blessed land, the Gu Master cannot self-detonate it. Otherwise, the chosen Gu instantly die, with no other effects. If the Gu has a self-detonation ability, it does not trigger, since the Gu was not activated.

Healing Gu

Gu have a pool of hit points, and need to be healed when damaged. Most Gu heal back to full health when they are fed. Some Gu can only be healed by other Gu or an obscure process.

Stacking Effects

In most cases, the effects of different Gu will

Even if a Gu Master owns multiple Golden Breeze Gu, they cannot sustain both at the same time to double the healing effect. If multiple Gu would transform the same body part, the most recently applied effect takes precedence.

Gu against Gu

Sometimes the effects of Gu will be pit against one another. In most circumstances, the higher rank Gu's effect takes precedence. If both are the same rank, the defending Gu should block the effect. For example, if a Gu Master is attacked by Rank 2 Vein Burst Gu, but has strengthened his **Circulatory System**

with Rank 2 Iron Artery Gu, then he would be unaffected, despite neither Gu explicitly mentioning the interaction. Invisibility and concealments are considered the defender when pit against divinations.

The Gu system has a lot of moving parts, and it would be unfun and tedious if every effect listed every possible counter and use case. When there’s uncertainty about whether a Gu would affect a target, use common sense, and if that fails the GM will have to make a ruling.

Recipes

Following a Recipe

Refinement recipes will have many required materials. Common materials are included in the recipe’s primeval stone cost, assuming you have access to a market to purchase the materials. Rarer materials will be specified, and you may have to seek out a seller or go find these materials yourself. When you successfully refine a Gu that you have never refined before, you immediately invest {0, 1, 2, 3, 4} experience into your Attainment in the path of the Gu.

To begin refinement, you must have all the necessary materials on hand. If you know any refinement techniques (see ch.2 - Talents) you may select one. Make a **Refinement** skill test with a penalty or bonus according to the recipe’s difficulty. If you’ve already successfully refined the Gu before, you gain a -20 bonus on the test. On a success, roll the failure die. If the number rolled is anything except a 1, you have succeeded in creating the Gu. If you do roll a 1, the refinement fails, representing the flat chance of failure all refinement recipes have.

On a failure, you lose all non-Gu refinement materials used in the refinement; you and all Gu being used in the refinement process take a backlash. If the failure was caused by a 1 on the failure die, the backlash is negated. Otherwise, you take damage to your soul equal to the degrees of failure. Every Gu being used in the refinement takes the same amount of damage to their health. If your Vital Gu would be killed in this manner, instead it drops to 1 hit point.

Refinement is an extremely precise and involved effort. For every 4 hours you spend refining Gu without a rest, you take 1 damage to your soul as you become fatigued.

Creating a Recipe

Creating a recipe is a collaborative effort between the player and GM. You should first approach the GM with the Gu you want to create a recipe for. This can be a Gu from the Gu Index or a unique Gu that the GM has approved, but you must have at least *Intermediate* Attainment in the path of the Gu. When you successfully create the recipe of a Gu, you immediately invest {1, 2, 4, 8, 20} experience into your Attainment in the path of the Gu.

You must spend a number of primeval stones on refinement materials and {8, 16, 24, 32, 40} hours practicing and experimenting; this time does not need to be sequential however. After spending the requisite time, make a **Refinement** skill test with a bonus or penalty according to the following table:

Rank	Bonus/Penalty
1	-20
2	0
3	+20
4	+40
5	+60

Alternatively, if you have a Gu with the **[Deductive]** keyword you may use the **Deduction** action to deduce the recipe. You still must meet the Attainment requirements, and also must have a **Refinement** skill of {20, 30, 40, 60, 80} to attempt to create a recipe with the **Deduction** action.

If you succeed the skill test, a recipe for the Gu is created. All that is left to do is actually design the recipe. The recipe begins with the following statistics and you can improve it by spending Recipe Points.

Sample Recipe

Sample Gu

Rank: {1, 2, 3, 4, 5}

Cost:

Rank	Cost
1	150 PS
2	750 PS
3	7,500 PS + 1 Rank 3 Refinement Material
4	75,000 PS + 2 Rank 4 Refinement Materials
5	1,500,000 PS + 2 Rank 5 Refinement Materials

Additional Gu: If this recipe upgrades a Gu to the next rank, that Gu goes here. You may also forcefully add a Gu to the refinement recipe so long as it is of the same path as the Gu being refined. If you do so, you gain 1 Recipe Point if the Gu is of rank {N/A, 1, 2, 3, 4} or 3 Recipe Points if the Gu is of rank {1, 2, 3, 4, 5}. You cannot add a Gu of higher rank into the refinement recipe.

Duration: 16 hours

Difficulty: {+10, +20, +40, +60, +100}

Failure Die: {d4, d4, d4, d2, d2}

When you succeed in deducing a recipe you have a number of Recipe Points equal to your degrees of success on the test, with a critical success counting as an additional degree of success. Spending a Recipe Point on the recipe does one of the following:

- The failure die is increased by one step; d2 -> d4 -> d6 -> d8 -> d10 -> d12 -> d20 -> d100
- The difficulty is reduced by 10
- The primeval stone cost is reduced by 25% (rounded down)
- The duration is reduced by 4 hours (to a minimum of 1 hour)

Once you have spent all Recipe Points, the recipe is complete!

Improving a Recipe

You can leverage your **Refinement** skill to reduce the cost, duration, difficulty, or failure rate of any Gu recipe. To do so, you must have *Fundamental* Attainment (see ch.2 - Talents) in the path of the Gu in question. When you successfully improve the recipe of a Gu, you immediately invest {1, 1, 2, 4, 8} experience into your Attainment in the path of the Gu.

Start by paying 4 times the total cost of the recipe, to represent the materials needed to practice

improving the recipe and take damage to your soul equal to the degrees of failure multiplied by the rank of the recipe. On a failure, you do not succeed in improving the recipe, but don't face a backlash. On a success, you make a breakthrough and gain a new recipe for the Gu, with one of the following improvements:

- The failure die is increased by one step; d2 -> d4 -> d6 -> d8 -> d10 -> d12 -> d20 -> d100
- The difficulty is reduced by 10
- The primeval stone cost is reduced by 25% (rounded down)
- The duration is reduced by 4 hours

If you roll a critical on your test, you may make two improvements instead of one. The recipe you've created is different from the previous one, and both can still be used and sold. You can improve a recipe a number of times equal to 5% of your **Refinement** skill, rounded down.

Alternatively, if you have a Gu with the [**Deductive**] keyword you may use the **Deduction** action to improve the recipe. You still must meet the Attainment requirements, and also must have a **Refinement** skill of {20, 20, 30, 40, 50} to attempt to improve a recipe with the **Deduction** action. This process takes {2, 4, 8, 12, 16} hours to perform.

Deductive

When activated, [**Deductive**] Gu unlock a special *Deduction* action. To take it, you must spend 4 hours to deduce a specific subject or a killer move and make a **Deduction** skill test. Penalties and bonuses are determined by the amount of supporting information available to you. You can stack the effects of a number [**Deductive**] Gu to the same *Deduction* action according to your Wisdom Path Attainment, given in the following table:

Attainment	Maximum [Deductive] Gu
None	1
Fundamental	2
Intermediate	3
Master	5

A specific subject can be something that occurred in the past, such as who might have committed a murder, or something happening in the present or future, like why a rival clan may have purchased a huge amount of an unusual refinement material. At the GM's discretion, you can also deduce plans of action, such as moneymaking schemes or attack plans. Deductions cannot create information out of thin air, and a success does not necessarily mean your deduction is correct if you lack a key piece of evidence. For every degree of success beyond 1 on the check, however, you gain one additional conclusion about the subject.

You may also use the *Deduction* action to create or improve refinement recipes. When you do so, you make the **Refinement** skill test like normal and add whatever effects are provided by the [**Deductive**] Gu you are using.

Dao

Gu with the [**Dao**] keyword contain much higher traces of dao than most mortal Gu. Dao of different paths naturally conflict, and a Gu Master cannot gain the effect from a [**Dao**] Gu if they are already under the effect of a [**Dao**] Gu of a non-compatible path. Path compatibilites are located on page 35. If a Gu belonging to Transformation Path has the [**Dao**] keyword, it belongs wholly to transformation path

and is compatible with all other paths.

Transformation Path Gu may instead have the [**Dao: [Path]**] keyword, indicating that the Dao belongs to a different path and inherits that path's compatibilities. For example, Earth Chief Zombie Gu, which has the [**Dao: Earth**] keyword, can only be combined with [**Dao**] Gu of Metal, Transformation, or Wood Path.

Using the same [**Dao**] Gu multiple times does not stack the effect unless specified in the Gu description. You may also not apply multiple [**Dao**] Gu to the same body part. Most [**Dao**] Gu will specify what body part they carve dao into, and if the Gu does not list a body part then it has no body part restrictions.

Full Body - [**Dao**] Gu with the [**Transformation**] keyword affect your full body, but you can still apply [**Dao**] Gu to other body parts as long as you still have that body part after transforming.

Head, Brain, Torso, Heart, Lungs, Aperture, Arms, Hands, Legs, Feet, Skin, Blood, Bones, Tendons, Nervous System, Circulatory System

Eyes - Whether the Gu affects one eye or both, it counts as augmenting your eyes.

Ears - Whether the Gu affects one ear or both, it counts as augmenting your ears.

Muscles - Can be a specific muscle or the entire muscular system. Beast Strength Gu are an exception, as they can strengthen muscles and still be combined with compatible muscle affecting [**Dao**] Gu. A Gu Master can only have up to 9 Beast Strength Gu effects at a time.

Defensive

[**Defensive**] Gu can be activated as a **Reaction** to any event.

Expendable X

[**Expendable**] Gu are destroyed after X uses. If there is no number, the Gu can only be used a single time before it is destroyed.

Extinct

[**Extinct**] Gu no longer appear naturally in the world and require extinct refinement materials for their most common recipes. **Refinement** and **Deduction** skill tests made to create a recipe for an [**Extinct**] Gu are made with an additional +60 penalty.

Fast

[**Fast**] Gu have a movement of 12 meters instead of 8.

Ingredient

Unique to Food Path, [**Ingredient**] Gu can be used to apply effects to meals you prepare. To prepare a meal, you must spend 30 minutes cooking; expend 1 primeval stone worth of materials and the total primeval essence cost of involved [**Ingredient**] Gu. The number of [**Ingredient**] Gu you can apply to the same meal is dependent on your Food Path Attainment. You cannot prepare a meal unless you have at least *Fundamental* Food Path Attainment.

Each meal can feed 5 creatures.

Attainment	Maximum Ingredients
Fundamental	2
Intermediate	3
Master	5

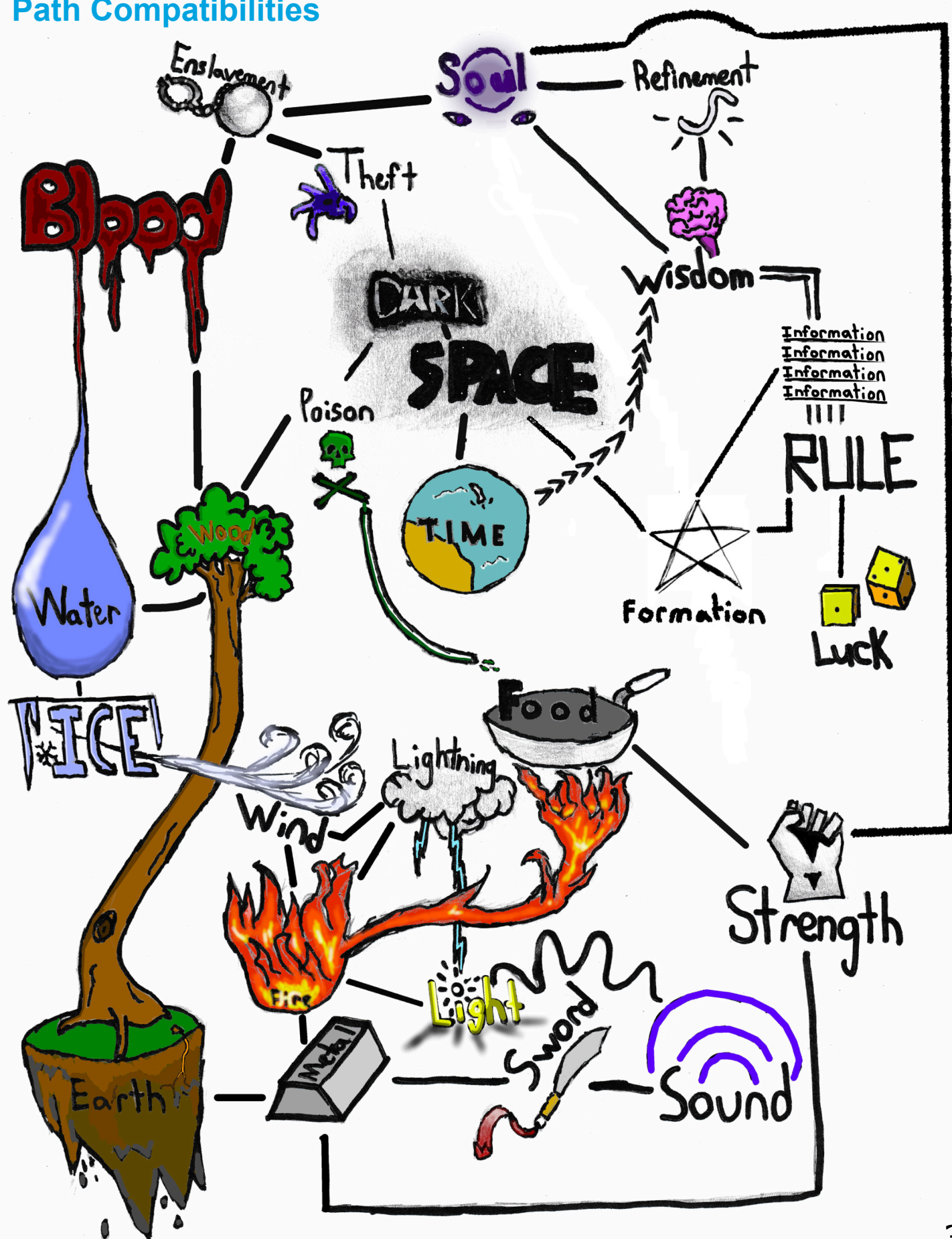
The effects of a meal last for 4 hours, and a creature can only be under the effect of one meal at a time.

Investigative

Most [**Investigative**] Gu are divinations that are used to detect your surroundings for creatures, Gu, or even specific objects. The keyword will always be followed by the sense it augments; there are [**Investigative: Sight**] Gu, [**Investigative: Hearing**] Gu, [**Investigative: Smell**] Gu, and [**Investigative: Detect**] Gu. Sight, hearing, and smell are self explanatory, and you cannot see or hear through sight or hearing [**Investigative**] Gu if you have the *blinded* or the *deafened* condition, respectively. Detect Gu transmit the locations of whatever Gu, objects, or creatures the Gu is meant to detect directly into your mind, and do not require the use of any of your senses. If you use an [**Investigative**] Gu besides sight while *blinded* to detect the location of a creature, the +40 penalty to **Close Combat** and **Ranged Attack** skill tests from the *blinded* condition is reduced to a +10 penalty.

Stealth effects like invisibility and illusions will usually specify one or more of the following:

Path Compatibilities



- Invisible - Cannot be seen normally or by [**Investigative: Sight**] Gu. Also a condition that can be applied to creatures and objects.
- Inaudible - Cannot be heard normally or by [**Investigative: Hearing**] Gu
- Odorless - Cannot be smelled normally or by [**Investigative: Smell**] Gu
- Undetectable - Cannot be detected by [**Investigative: Detect**] Gu

If the [**Investigative**] Gu is of high enough rank, it ignores the stealthing or illusory effect entirely. Unless otherwise specified, [**Investigative**] Gu ignore stealthing effects of a lower rank.

Low Vitality

[**Low Vitality**] Gu do not regenerate hit points when they are fed. They will clarify the necessary Gu or process used to recover their health instead.

Piercing

[**Piercing**] Gu can pierce through any material that lacks dao. The only barriers with dao would be either immortal refinement materials or barriers created by Gu. Mundane armor worn by a creature struck by a [**Piercing**] attack does not reduce the damage of the attack, and the armor takes damage equal to the damage of the attack to its hit points.

[**Piercing**] Gu can also make attacks against targets fully obscured by cover with a +20 penalty. If the target is only partially obscured by cover, or if you know exactly where they are like from an [**Investigative**] Gu, attacks made with a [**Piercing**] Gu against them do not have the usual cover penalty.

Shield

When you take damage, that damage is first assigned to any active Gu with the [**Shield**] keyword so long as the Gu can block that damage type. If you have multiple [**Shield**] Gu active and it isn't immediately clear which one would block the attack first, you may decide in what order damage is assigned. If you use a [**Shield**] Gu to reduce damage, the Gu takes that damage to its hitpoints.

If a [**Shield**] Gu would die from sustaining an attack while active, you may use a **Reaction** to deactivate the Gu at 1 hit point, taking the remaining damage to your hit points or another [**Shield**] Gu.

Size

If size is not listed, the Gu is the most common size, [**Tiny**]; that of a large insect. If the Gu is [**Small**] it is the size of a child, and [**Medium**] is the size of a man. [**Large**] Gu take up 4 squares when outside of your aperture, and [**Huge**] Gu take up 9 or more squares. Creatures and objects also have a size.

Size	Modifier to Hit
Tiny	+40
Small	+20
Medium	0
Large	-20
Huge	-40

Steed

[**Steed**] Gu are typically larger than regular Gu and can be ridden while outside your aperture. They also come with a statblock, unlike most other Gu, as they are capable of fighting beyond just activating themselves. That being said, they do not have regular anatomy and are completely unaffected by injuries. It is impossible to sever a [**Steed**] Gu's limbs until it is dead, and it has immunity to the *bleeding*, *blinded* and *deafened* conditions. Unless a poison specifically states it works on Gu, Gu are immune to the *poisoned* condition.

While mounted, you cannot move but instead move with the [**Steed**]. The [**Steed**] Gu shares your initiative and both of your turns are taken simultaneously. You decide what **Reactions** are taken by a refined [**Steed**] Gu, but each **Reaction** it takes expends one of your **Reactions**. If you take the **Dodge Reaction** while mounted, you must dismount and move at least one meter like normal, beginning by moving to a square adjacent to the mount.

Wild [**Steed**] Gu are often difficult to refine as they act more similar to beasts than other Gu, but once refined they cease to move or attack and only act as your will directs them to. Controlling a refined [**Steed**] Gu is as easy moving your fingers and does not harm your soul.

Supplementary

Supplementary Gu can change the properties of your subsequent activations. When used outside of killer moves, [**Supplementary**] Gu have no effect on Gu of a higher rank than itself. When used as supplementary Gu in a killer move, you will require a number of the same [**Supplementary**] Gu to properly apply the effect equal to:

$$2^{(\text{killer move rank} - [\text{Supplementary}] \text{ Gu rank})}$$

Supplementary Gu inherit the [**Sustained**] keyword when used to augment [**Sustained**] Gu.

Sustained

You must pay the cost of [**Sustained**] Gu at the start of each of your turns as long as you keep the effect active. Paying the cost does not use one of your activations. While a Gu is being sustained, it cannot be activated (because it is already active). Take 1 damage to your soul for each Gu beyond your **Activations** Attribute that you sustain at the start of each of your turns.

You may stop sustaining a Gu at any time, whether or not it is your turn. If you fall *unconscious* or are *stunned*, you automatically stop sustaining all Gu. When you stop sustaining a Gu, you cannot activate that Gu again until the start of your next turn.

Split Second

Attacks made with [**Split Second**] Gu are too fast for the defender to react in time. When a creature uses a **Reaction** in response to the activation or effect of an [**Split Second**] Gu, their **Reaction** is delayed until after the Gu's successful activation and application of its effect.

Transformation

Gu and, more commonly, killer moves with the **[Transformation]** keyword completely change the body of the user, granting it different Attributes. The most common Attribute changed is hit points, though some change other Attributes like movement and strength. If your hit point or soul maximums are changed by a **[Transformation]** Gu, keep track of how much health or soul you had before the transformation. When the transformation ends, either by being reduced to 0 hit points/soul or by deactivating the Gu, Your Attributes return to their state before the transformation, including current hit points/soul. You may only ever be under the effect of one **[Transformation]** Gu or killer move at a time.

If your transformation is reduced to 0 hit points, all Gu involved deactivate and any remaining damage from the attack is dealt to your hit points. If the transformation was permanent and is reduced to 0 hit points, you remain in the transformation and roll to see if you enter *Final Stand* (see Ch. 4, Combat).

Undodgeable

[Undodgeable] attacks cannot be avoided by moving, such as with the **Dodge Reaction**. A creature can still take the **Dodge Reaction** against an **[Undodgeable]** attack, but it will only move them and not avoid the attack.

Unrefinable

[Unrefinable] Gu exclusively appear naturally in the world. It is impossible to create a recipe for Gu with this keyword.

Vital

A Gu Master can only have 1 **[Vital]** Gu at a time. If a Gu with the **[Vital]** keyword dies, the owner of the Gu dies as well. When taking damage from refinement backlash, a **[Vital]** Gu cannot be brought below 1 hit point. The **[Vital]** keyword is applied automatically to the first Gu a Gu Master refines, but you can spend a day in closed cultivation with a new Gu to transfer the **[Vital]** keyword to the new Gu, removing it from your old Vital Gu. When you change your Vital Gu, your current hit points are reduced to 1 as you suffer backlash.

Creating Unique Gu

While I've made an expansive list of many of the Gu paths, in reality there is a basically unlimited number of Gu. Once you're more familiar with the system and balance, you're encouraged to make your own Gu. Here are some guidelines;

- Gu type (attack, guard, celerity, etc.) has no mechanical effect and only exists for easier categorization.
- Rank 5 Gu are at the peak of the mortal realm, and have the power to clear sections of a battlefield single handedly, while rank 1 Gu are sometimes strong enough to kill a person. Keep in mind that a Gu of higher rank should have an advantage over lower ranked Gu.
- The rules already account for the differing primeval essence quality between ranks. Costs are proportional to the power of the Gu within its rank. A rank 1 Gu with a high cost can be similar in strength to a rank 2 Gu with low cost.
- Health is usually only relevant to Gu with the **[Shield]** or **[Steed]** keywords or for refinement. Gu with higher health are more likely to survive backlash from refinement and are thus more viable for improvement. Most Gu should have between 1-6 health, but **[Shield]** Gu start from 40-80 health at rank 1 and scale to 1000-1500 at rank 5, fluctuating based on the defensive strength of the path and any weaknesses or strengths the Gu has.
- Range can be Self, Touch, or a distance in meters.
- Duration can be permanent or have a specified duration. Duration can be in the form of time (minutes/hours/days/years) or with respect to the turn. If the Gu applies an effect for 1 turn, its typically better to say "until the end of your/their next turn." This is because the number of turns remaining on an effect ticks down at the end of the creature's turn; if you buff yourself on your turn, and the duration of the effect is 1 turn, it would disappear at the end of your turn.
- Overall, the strength of the Gu should be relative to all these factors. If it is more expensive in primeval essence, has a short range, eats expensive food, and/or has major drawbacks to its use, the power of the Gu should be increased relatively. This can mean more damage, more health (for **[Shield]** Gu), making the Gu harder to counter, and so on. A Gu that costs 2 portions, eats dirt, and affects 1km better have a much weaker effect than other Gu in its rank. Adding the **[Expendable]** or **[Low Vitality]** keywords can also be used to balance a Gu that's on the stronger side.

Most importantly, be creative! There is a Gu for any purpose you can think of. There are Gu suited to cure any affliction, make any attack, cause any event that you can think of. Some Gu might seem practically useless, but they can always be used to improve some killer move or refine a new Gu.

Path Compatibilities

On the following page, you can find a diagram showing the path compatibilities. All compatibilities go both ways, no matter how it is visually represented (i.e. Wisdom Path and Time Path can always be combined with each other, regardless of what order they are applied in). Transformation Path is not included on the diagram since it is compatible with all other paths.

Beasts and Enslavement Path

Beasts

Species

Beasts have a species and a type. The species is the general creature; lightning wolves, turtleback wolves, and azure wolves are all of the wolf species. Type is the subspecies; lightning wolves are a different type of wolf than turtleback wolves.

Class

The class of beasts from low to high is as follows: ordinary beast, Hundred Beast King, Thousand Beast King, Myriad Beast King, Beast Emperor. When the minimum threshold for the population of the same type of beast is crossed, there is a random chance a beast in the group will mutate into the proper beast king. Hundred Beast Kings at 100 beasts, Thousand at 1,000, Myriad at 10,000, and Beast Emperor at 100,000. The beast king immediately forms a *Horde* as the *Commander* and no new beast kings of the same class. The beast king is usually larger and stronger than the other beasts of lower class, and its base **Battle Strength** is 10 times higher than that of the previous class. Wild Gu will also sometimes attach to wild beast kings, but will attempt to flee if the beast is heavily wounded, killed, or enslaved. Rank 1 Gu attach to Hundred Beast Kings, rank 2 to Thousand Beast Kings, and so on. **Mutated** beast kings attract rank 5 Gu. Wild beast kings can have up to 3, with each one increasing the **Battle Strength** of the beast by {25, 50, 125, 500, 10,000}.

Wild Gu on a beast king can choose to activate one time at any point on the beast's turn, or in **Reaction** to a trigger if the Gu could ordinarily be activated as a **Reaction** to the triggering effect. Gu with the **[Sustained]** keyword will usually be sustained every turn.

Beasts will generally have higher Fortitude than humans, as well as a further increased pool of hit points. Stat blocks will indicate the beast's HP Multiplier; it's maximum hit points are equal to their Fortitude Attribute multiplied by the HP Multiplier.

Grade

Every beast has a grade that determines how strong a certain number of beasts is in comparison to others. **Chaff** are the weakest, typically being **[Tiny]** or **[Small]** creatures with high reproduction rates like rats, fish, birds, and bugs. Every **Chaff** beast has just 1 **Battle Strength**. **Standard** grade beasts are usually bulkier, such as boars, wolves, or horses. Every **Standard** beast has 3 **Battle Strength**. **Elite** beasts are powerful fighters like bears, elephants, and tigers, and each one has 50 **Battle Strength**. **Mutated** beasts are freaks of nature with battle strength rivalling a rank 4 Gu Master. Shark-fin Wolves, Eerie Fire Dragon Pythons, and Mound Tigers are among them, and each one has 5,000 **Battle Strength**.

Market Prices

Market Price given Class and Grade	Ordinary	100 BK	1,000 BK	Myriad BK	Emperor
Chaff	1	20	1,000	50,000	500,000
Standard	20	1,000	50,000	500,000	2,000,000
Elite	1,000	50,000	500,000	2,000,000	5,000,000
Mutated	50,000	500,000+	-	-	-

Beast Groups

Most beasts are not solitary and form beast groups in the wild. All *Hordes* are also beast groups, but a beast group is only a *Horde* if it has a *Commander*.

Wild Beast Groups

Wild beasts in a suitable environment will form larger and larger beast groups so long as their territory can sustain them. Generally, larger beast groups are located further from large settlements of Gu Masters, but when their ecosystem can no longer sustain their numbers, these *Hordes* become a beast tide that floods into a new region, devouring everything in their wake.

Movement

When a beast group moves on their turn, they move to and fill an adjacent area. The distance a beast group moves is equal to triple their Movement statistic in meters each turn.

Reproduction

Every beast has a reproduction rate from 1 to 4. Every week a beast group stays settled in one of its **Preferred Habitats** or **Secondary Habitats**, the population increases by the relevant percentage, rounded down to a minimum of 1 beast. The final number is halved if in the beast's **Secondary Habitat**. This calculation is done after calculating any casualties taken from their biome or due to not paying the primeval stone upkeep cost. There must be a minimum of 50 beasts in a beast group to reproduce.

Reproduction Rate	Percentage Increase
1	1
2	5
3	10
4	20

*A wild Horde of 4,500 turtleback wolves are settled in a mountain. Since mountains are one of their Secondary Habitats, and they have a reproduction rate of 2 (5 percent, halved to 2.5 percent), after a week their population increases by 2.5%. $4,500 * 1.025 = 4,612.5$, rounded down to now 4,612 beasts in the Horde.*

Areas

An area is just the amount of space required to hold a beast group. It can be as small as a grove or as large as a forest, but every area has a particular biome that dictates battle conditions (when a *Horde* is fighting non-player characters) as well as the amount of food the beast group can hunt or scavenge for sustenance and reproduction. Every beast has a list of **Preferred Habitats** and **Secondary Habitats**. While settled in a **Preferred Habitat**, a beast group's primeval stone upkeep cost is halved and they reproduce at the normal rate. While settled in a **Secondary Habitat**, a beast group's primeval stone upkeep cost is reduced by 20% and they reproduce at half the normal rate. If the *Horde* is staying in a biome not included in either, the primeval stone upkeep cost is unchanged and the *Horde* no longer reproduces.

Due to its extreme topography, Southern Border is home to far more biomes than any of the other outer regions.

Jungle: Beast Groups that don't have Jungles as their **Preferred Habitat** lose 1% of their population as casualties each day they stay in the Jungle. If Jungles also aren't one of their **Secondary Habitats**, they instead take 5% of their population in casualties this way. Beast Kings and **Mutated** beasts cannot die in this way.

Hills:

Forest:

Mountains: Defenders have their **Battle Strength** multiplied by 2 after all modifiers. Beast groups that don't have mountains as a **Preferred Biome** consider mountains *Difficult Terrain*, unless they can fly.

Marsh: Land and aquatic creatures can settle in marshes. Almost entirely *Difficult Terrain*, unless the beast doesn't consider water *Difficult Terrain* or can fly.

River: Only aquatic creatures can settle in rivers. Non-aquatic *Hordes* cannot engulf creatures in a river.

Grove: Any time a beast group reproduces in a Grove, they produce 50% more offspring (rounded down).

Cave: Unless light is produced, *Hordes* and their *Commanders* without a feature to see or perceive things in the dark have their total **Battle Strength** halved after modifiers.

Jungle: If a beast group stays in a jungle for more than a day at a time and does not have it as a **Preferred Biome**, they take 1% of their population (rounded down to a minimum of 1 beast) in casualties every day, doubled to 2% if it also isn't their **Secondary Biome**. **Mutated** beasts do not lose population in this way.

Awareness skill tests made to detect hidden creatures are made with disadvantage in a jungle.

Enslavement Path

Enslavement path Gu Masters are a huge asset to a clan. In battle, a single enslavement path Gu Master can be worth many other Gu Masters of the same rank, as they use Enslavement Gu to dominate the minds of beasts and even other Gu Masters to be used as a personal army. Enslavement path is an uncommon one to follow, however, as it costs a great deal of resources to maintain an army of beasts. To cultivate Enslavement Path, a Gu Master must also have a strong soul foundation or else their results will be very limited.

There are two different enslavement Gu, both belonging to Enslavement Path: [Beast] Enslavement Gu exist for pretty much all wild beasts; in the Southern Border, wolves and boars are a common target, but some Gu Masters create armies of horses, monkeys, goats, and even birds. [Beast] Enslavement Gu always cover a specific animal type; Wolf Enslavement Gu can enslave wolves, vermillion flame wolves, shark fin wolves, etc., but they cannot enslave dogs, which are of course enslaved with a Dog Enslavement Gu. Slavery Gu is the other enslavement Gu is used to enslave other humans and variant-humans. Both Gu exist from Rank 1 to 5, able to enslave more powerful creatures at higher ranks.

Direct Control

Commanding individual beasts is tedious and quickly drains the soul. When you individually control a creature, you take its turn for it, and take 1 damage to your soul at the end of its turn. You may choose what **Reactions** it takes until the start of your next turn, but every **Reaction** it takes expends one of your **Reactions**. You can choose to individually control any beast that is not part of a *Horde* (beast kings must be individually controlled while part of a *Horde*). If you do not take an enslaved beast's turn, it acts like a wild beast and is under the GM's command, but will usually follow what the *Horde* is doing and never attack friendly creatures.

Hordes

Hordes are large groups of a specific type of beast led by a beast king, and can be either wild or enslaved. *Hordes* occupy entire areas based on their size, and the space they can cover is very flexible. A *Horde* of 1,000 [Medium] beasts occupies a footprint of roughly 100 square meters while on the move, and collapses to half that size when attacking. This means a maximum-size *Horde* with 1,000,000 beasts covers roughly 100 square kilometers. *Hordes* cannot occupy the same area as another *Horde* unless it is attacking that area.

When you successfully enslave a beast king, their entire *Horde* becomes controlled by you. They do not become enslaved and cannot be individually controlled by you, but nonetheless follow your orders given by the *Direct Combat Action*. A *Horde* of beasts has a minimum of 20 creatures, and each *Horde* must be composed of one type of ordinary beast led by a beast king of the same species. The beast king leading the *Horde* is the *Commander*.

Horde Size	Number of Beasts	Damage / Order	Lieutenant Class
Swarm	100 - 999	1	No Lieutenants
Lesser Horde	1,000 - 9,999	20	Hundred BK
Greater Horde	10,000 - 99,999	30	Thousand BK
Myriad Horde	100,000 - 1,000,000	50	Myriad BK

The maximum number of beasts in a *Commander's Horde* is listed below:

- Hundred Beast King: 1,000
- Thousand Beast King: 10,000
- Myriad Beast King: 100,000
- Beast Emperor: 1,000,000
- Mutated Beast King: 1,000 Mutated Beasts

Beast kings of a class lower than the *Horde's* Lieutenants are assumed to be present in the *Horde*, but their **Battle Strength** should not be included in the total for the *Horde* to simplify calculations. If you acquire more than 1,000,000 beasts or 1,000 mutated beasts, the remainder must be assigned to a different *Horde*.

Lieutenants

Up to 10 enslaved Beast Kings of the proper classification can be included in the *Horde* as Lieutenants. Each Lieutenant takes on some of the mental toll that commanding an army exerts, reducing the damage you take to your soul when giving the *Horde* an order by 2, to a minimum of 1 damage.

Horde on Horde Combat

When two *Hordes* clash, calculate the total **Battle Strength** of both *Hordes*. A *Horde's* **Battle Strength** is equal to the number of beasts multiplied by the individual beast's **Battle Strength** value, plus the **Battle Strength** of the *Commander* and all Lieutenants. Each turn, both *Hordes* gain **Casualty Points** equal to the opposing *Horde's* **Battle Strength**.

When a *Horde's* **Casualty Points** exceed the **Battle Strength** value of a single beast, casualties are dealt. Divide the *Horde's* current **Casualty Points** by the individual beast's **Battle Strength**, rounded down — that many beasts die. The *Horde's* **Casualty Points** are then reduced by the number of casualties multiplied by the

individual beast's **Battle Strength**, carrying the remainder forward into the next turn. When combat ends, all **Casualty Points** are removed.

Lieutenants do not have their own **Casualty Point** threshold. Instead, whenever the *Horde* takes 5% or more of its population in casualties on a single turn, roll 1d4. On a 1, one Lieutenant dies. The controlling Gu Master chooses which Lieutenant is lost. If there are no Lieutenants remaining, this roll is ignored.

Upkeep

Every beast has an upkeep cost. This number represents the number of primeval stones you must spend on its food each week to keep it from starving, and is heavily reduced if the beast group is settled in its **Preferred Habitat**. If you do not pay the full upkeep cost, 5% of the beasts in the beast group die each week, rounded down to a minimum of 1 beast.

Directing

As long as you have at least one *Horde* under your control and within your range of control (**Maximum Soul** meters), you can use the *Direct **Combat Action***.

Direct (**Combat Action**)

You give up to one order to each of your *Hordes*. At the end of your turn, you take damage to your soul for every order you gave, dependent on the size of the *Horde*. Wild beast kings do not take damage to their soul when they take the *Direct **Combat Action***. If a beast group does not receive an order, they continue following the last order given to them if possible. If there are no orders to follow, the beasts act like wild animals, creating dens and nests and hunting in their surroundings.

Engulfing

When a *Horde* moves into an area, defenders only have two options; flee, which is only possible if the defender is faster than the beasts that make up the *Horde*, or be engulfed. When you are engulfed by a *Horde*, the ordinary battle map is still used, but every unoccupied square is treated as though occupied by a member of the horde. Creatures can still move, but any movement is considered to be through *Difficult Terrain*. This can be avoided by flying so long as the members of the *Horde* do not have a flying speed. Some unoccupied squares may be ignored at the GM's discretion, like if you are defending a doorway and have no beasts at your back, none of the squares inside would count.

During the *Horde's* turn, you are subject to a number of the beast's **Primary Attacks** depending on the **Base Attacks** of the *Horde*, size of the beast in question, and the number of adjacent squares occupied by a member of the *Horde*. These attacks automatically hit.

Attacking a Horde

Single-target attacks targeting the *Horde* automatically hit without a skill test. They are completely ineffective unless they deal more damage than the beast comprising the *Horde* has Hit Points. If the attack deals enough damage, it kills a number of beasts in the *Horde* equal to the damage dealt divided by the maximum hit points of the beast. *Hordes* cannot be inflicted with status effects from single-target attacks.

Area of Effect attacks deal damage to the *Horde* differently. When an AoE strikes an area occupied by a Horde, If the attack deals more damage than the beast has hit points determine the number of squares the AoE covers that are occupied by the Horde. AoE attacks can inflict status effects on a *Horde* as long as they

affect 10 or more squares occupied by the *Horde*.

Beast Size

The size of the beast in the *Horde* determines two things when engulfing you: how many attacks it makes per adjacent square occupied by a member of the *Horde*, and how many casualties the *Horde* takes when it is hit with an area of effect attack. Take the **Number of Attacks** statistic of the beast composing the *Horde* and multiply it by the relevant multiplier to find the number of attacks made. When a *Horde* is hit with area of effect attack, the casualties taken are multiplied by the same number.

Beast Size	Multiplier
Tiny	10
Small	4
Medium	No multiplier, use base values
Large	1/2
Huge	1/4

Status Effects

Hordes are immune to the *airborne*, *bleeding*, *fatigued*, *prone*, and *restrained* conditions.

Engulfing NPCs

If a group of non-player Gu Masters are engulfed by a *Horde*, calculate the total **Battle Strength** of both sides, including any Beast Kings in the *Horde*. Each turn, both sides gain a number of **Casualty Points** equal to 10% of the opponents' **Battle Strength**. When calculating a group of Gu Masters' total **Battle Strength**, apply a simplification rule: ignore any Gu Master whose **Battle Strength** is less than 10% of the highest **Battle Strength** in the group. If their group ever has more than that amount in **Casualty Points**, all Gu Masters ignored in this way die. When the **Casualty Points** of the group exceeds the **Battle Strength** of the weakest unignored Gu Master, they and all ignored Gu Masters die and the total **Casualty Points** of the group are reduced by their **Battle Strength**. If the remaining **Casualty Points** are higher than the next weakest Gu Master's **Battle Strength**, that Gu Master dies as well, reducing the **Casualty Points** again and continuing until the **Casualty Points** are below the weakest Gu Master's **Battle Strength**.

Whenever a *Horde* takes **Casualty Points**, it takes a number of casualties equal to the **Casualty Points** divided by the beast's individual **Battle Strength**. The *Horde's Casualty Points* are then reduced by the number of casualties multiplied by the beast's individual **Battle Strength**.

If the Gu Masters' total **Battle Strength** is higher than that of the *Horde's Commander*, they can choose to focus fire the *Commander*. If they choose to on a turn, compare their total **Battle Strength** to that of the *Commander*. Roll 1d4, plus an additional die for every 10% higher the Gu Masters' total **Battle Strength** is. The *Commander* loses a percentage of its hit points equal to 10 times the number rolled. If the *Commander* is killed, the *Horde* breaks. Any beasts not personally enslaved by you revert to their wild state and seek a safe place to settle, fleeing the battle if possible. The highest ranked Beast Kings that were in the *Horde* form their own *Hordes* at the end of the next turn; these *Hordes* are under your control if the new *Commander* is enslaved by you.

Flanking

Hordes can only occupy the same area as another *Horde* if they are fighting each other, or if one *Horde* uses the flank order to flank a group of creatures already engaged with a friendly *Horde*. Flanked creatures take double the **Casualty Points**.

Defenses

Gu Masters often face down beast tides at their clan walls or fortresses. Defenses multiplicatively increase the total **Battle Strength** of defending Gu Masters. Wooden walls multiply their **Battle Strength** by 4, and stone walls by 10. Defensive Gu formations each provide {200, 2,000, 20,000, 200,000, 2,000,000} **Battle Strength** to the defending side, depending on the rank of the formation.

Orders

Many beasts have unique orders in addition to the generic orders listed here.

Defend

The *Horde* stays in its current position, attacking and engulfing any creatures that approach their location.

Flank

The *Horde* moves around the side of an area before attacking it. If the creatures in the area are already engulfed by a friendly *Horde*, they are now considered flanked. This order fails if the *Horde* cannot flank the target, such as if they are defending a tight mountain pass or are surrounded by walls.

Attack

The *Horde* moves to an area, attacking and engulfing any creatures it comes across. Any order besides Attack can be given in addition to the Attack order; as soon as the attacked area is free of any enemies, the *Horde* attempts to follow the second order.

If the *Horde* attacks an area already attacked by a friendly *Horde* from the opposite direction, any creatures engulfed are flanked.

Pursue

The *Horde* follows a group of creatures or a specific creature, engulfing them if they catch up to the area they are in.

Withdraw

The *Horde* retreats to an area, breaking any active engulfments.

Disperse

The *Horde* spreads out in all directions, breaking any active engulfments and no longer being a viable target for attacks. The next order given to the *Horde* must be to **Regroup**.

Regroup

Can only be given to a dispersed *Horde*. The *Horde* retreats to an area and then collects itself, engulfing any creatures in the area.

Killer Moves

When multiple Gu are combined into a single effect it is colloquially known as a killer move. Killer moves have a core of 1 or more same-ranked Gu as well as any number of supplemental Gu.

Blood Vision

Rank 4 Divination Killer Move

Core Gu: Rank 4 Blood Sense Gu, Rank 4 Blood Brother Gu

Supplementary Gu: Rank 4 Ten Meter Gu,

Total Activations: 4

Activation Cost: 49 portions

Keywords: **[Investigative: Detect]**, **[Sustained]**

Effect: Any creatures within 10 meters have their blood tainted with yours. These creatures are permanently considered your siblings by blood path methods. While this killer move is sustained, you can sense the exact location of any of your blood relatives within 10 meters.

Components of a Killer Move

Core Gu

Core Gu are the most important part of a killer move, and determine the main paths, rank, and general effect of the killer move. Looking at the Rank 4 killer move Blood Vision, shown above, It uses Rank 4 Blood Sense Gu and Rank 4 Blood Brother Gu as its core. Blood Brother Gu can turn a creature into your blood relative, and Blood Sense Gu senses the location of blood relatives nearby, so a natural effect would be to both transmute the blood of and sense nearby creatures. These are also both Blood Path Gu, and thus the killer move belongs to Blood Path as well. Finally, the Rank of the killer move is equal to the highest ranked Gu among the killer move's core.

Supplementary Gu

Supplementary Gu are used to amplify or mutate the effects of the core Gu. Supplementary Gu can be of a different path and even a higher rank than the core Gu, but must have the **[Supplementary]** keyword and do not change the overall rank of the killer move. If the supplementary Gu is of a lower rank than the killer move, you must have $2^{(\text{killer move rank} - [\text{Supplementary}]\text{ Gu rank})}$ of the Gu in the killer move for it to have any effect.

Activations

The activations stat is simply the number of Gu in the Killer Move. More complicated killer moves use many Gu and are more taxing on the user's soul. For each Gu over your Activations Attribute, your soul takes 1 damage upon activation. Every Gu in the killer move counts towards your number of currently sustained Gu if the killer move has the **[Sustained]** keyword.

Activation Cost

The combined primeval essence cost of all Gu in the recipe. This number assumes the user is of the same rank as the killer move. If the user is of a higher or lower rank, adjust the cost accordingly.

Expendable Gu

Gu with the **[Expendable]** keyword can be involved in a killer move even if killer moves themselves cannot have the **[Expendable]** keyword. When you activate the killer move, just expend the **[Expendable]** Gu as if you had activated it.

Shields

If your killer move has the **[Shield]** keyword, it has a total pool of hit points equal to the sum of the current hit points of all **[Shield]** Gu involved; any damage assigned to the killer move's hit points are dealt to the component Gu when you stop deactivating the killer move or if the killer move's hit points are reduced to 0. When this happens, you must assign the damage to any number of **[Shield]** Gu in the killer move in any way you wish to divide it, but of course you cannot assign more damage to a Gu than its current hit points.

Restrictions

Killer moves cannot be constructed around single-use permanent buffs like Beast Strength Gu to make the permanent effect even stronger. Killer moves also cannot have any of the following keywords: **[Defensive]** **[Expendable]** **[Extinct]** **[Fast]** **[Ingredient]** **[Low Vitality]** **[Supplementary]** **[Unrefinable]** **[Vital]**

Deducing a Killer Move

To deduce a killer move, you must have *Fundamental* Attainment in the paths of all Core Gu. You should prepare the killer move with the GM first, making sure both of you agree on the Gu used and the final effect. Once you have the killer move prepared, your character has to then spend time experimenting to create the killer move. This takes 8 hours for each unique Gu in the killer move, whether it is core or supplementary. After spending the requisite time practicing, in a single session or multiple, make a **Deduction** skill test with a +10 penalty for each unique Gu in the killer move beyond 2. If you have a Gu with the **[Deductive]** keyword, you may deduce the killer move using that Gu to improve your skill test. If you succeed, the killer move is created and you immediately invest experience into any paths the Core Gu belong to equal to the sum of the ranks of all Core Gu belonging to that path. If you had deduced Blood Vision for example, you would invest 8 experience into Blood Path, 4 for each rank 4 core Gu.

Constructing the Killer Move

When you create a killer move, start with a single core Gu to determine the primary effect of the killer move. The type (attack, divination, manifestation, etc.) and keywords of the killer move are identical to the type and keywords of the first core Gu, as is the initial effect.

When you add another core Gu, the effect is augmented, adding the damage or effect of the added Gu to the effect of the first. If the range of the added Gu is smaller than the range of the first Gu, any damage added is halved (rounded down to a minimum of 1) and any effects with a duration have that duration reduced by half (rounded down to a minimum of 1 turn). If you can justify it, you may also add keywords from added Gu to the killer move.

Many effects are more abstract than just "do X damage" and it is up to you and the GM to determine how certain effects work together while remaining relatively balanced. The GM has the final say on the effect of the killer move, but both of you should feel free to modify the killer move's statistics later if it turns out too strong or too weak.

Activating a Killer Move

Killer moves can be activated with the **Activate a Killer Move *Combat Action***, but can be quite taxing on the soul depending on their complexity. Pick a killer move for which you have all the Gu and enough primeval essence for all activations. For every activation in the killer move over your **Activations** Attribute, take 1 damage to your soul. The killer move activates, applying its effect. If the killer move has the **[Sustained]** keyword, you take 1 damage to your soul any time you activate a Gu while sustaining the killer move.

Gu Formations

Gu formations are special types of killer moves that can be placed in the world and kept active for a period of time, without requiring any user input beyond setting them up. Most formations are stationary, but large forces often have special-made Gu houses which can hold Gu Masters and be used as vehicles and weapons.

Activating a Gu Formation

Gu formations can be activated by any Gu Master touching any Gu in the formation. When you wish to activate a formation, the formation first expends primeval essence from any connected container Gu before being expended from your primeval sea. Of course, if there is not enough essence between the two to activate the formation, the activation fails and no primeval essence is expended. If the formation activates, you get to choose the targets of the killer move if it is targeted; if it has a range of Self or Touch and no targeter Gu to change the target, the effect is applied to you.

Creating a Gu Formation

Gu formations have Core Gu, Supplementary Gu, and an Activation Cost, but the number of Activations is limited by your Formation Path Attainment. Formations also require an essence container, injector, and activation trigger Gu to manage the formation, as well as a targeter if the formation has a targeted effect or you wish to change the target.

The simplest Gu formation consists of a single Gu

Attainment	Maximum Activations
None	6
Fundamental	10
Intermediate	15
Master	40

Essence Container

Any container Gu that can store primeval essence can be used as the essence container of a formation, and a formation can have as many essence containers as you wish. These store all the primeval essence that will be used to activate the formation, and when they run dry, the formation ceases to function.

Injector

Injector Gu regulate the frequency of the formation's effects. A formation has a single injector that, when given a signal by an activation trigger or gate, activates the formation once, multiple times, or continuously.

Activation Triggers

The activation triggers act as the circuit that determines whether the formation is on or off. There are a large number of activation trigger Gu, and some of the more common are verbal triggers and proximity triggers. A formation can have as many activation triggers as you wish, but their primeval essence cost is added to the total cost of the formation.

Gates

A few logic gates exist, like And Gu, Or Gu, and Not Gu. These can be used to customize the activation triggers; for example, using And Gu, you can make a formation activate while a creature is within 5 meters AND the creature is not a blood relative of yours, thus creating a trap formation that only your family can pass by. A formation can have as many gates as you wish, but their primeval essence cost is added to the total cost of the formation.

Targeters

When formations activate, they are not typically controlled by a Gu Master, and thus need to be told what targets to choose. Different targeters give different filters for targeting and can be combined to create very specialized targeting parameters. A formation can have as many targeters as you wish, but their primeval essence cost is added to the total cost of the formation.

Gu Houses

Gu houses are exceedingly complex and can take many years to develop, as well as requiring training to pilot one. Each Gu house consists of a body, usually several flying methods, and many killer moves that can be separately activated by the pilot.

To create a Gu House, you must have Master Attainment in Formation Path and in the paths of all core Gu.

Chapter 4: Combat

Actions and the Initiative

At the beginning of combat, an initiative is rolled. If an enemy is within 2 meters of you, roll **Close Combat**. If not, roll **Ranged Attack**. The player with the most degrees of success goes first. In the case of ties, the lower number on the die goes first. If this is still tied, creatures controlled by a player go before non player characters. If the tied creatures are all player characters, they decide amongst themselves who goes first; if all are NPCs, the GM chooses. Continue this process for the rest of the combatants.

Surprise

Surprised creatures have a +20 penalty to their initiative roll and cannot take **Reactions** until the start of their first turn.

Stealth

There is no stealth skill in the game. Many Gu render your personal sneaking skills worthless, and so most Gu Masters that wish to walk unobserved will use concealment Gu to do so. In the case either party is not using these Gu, the creature you are trying not to be detected by makes an **Awareness** skill test with a penalty or bonus determined by the GM for the circumstance, including the stealthing party's measures to hide themselves. If the stealthing party is *invisible*, creatures cannot make **Awareness** skill tests to perceive them unless they take an action that makes noise.

The Turn

One turn lasts 10 seconds.

Start and End of Turn Effects

If you have multiple start or end of turn effects, you choose in what order they resolve. If an effect is applied to a creature for a specified duration, say 3 turns, the number of turns remaining ticks down at the end of the creature's turns, with the effect ending if it hits 0.

Action Economy

Gu Masters can take a **Combat Action**, two **Reactions**, a **Bonus Action**, and a movement on each of their turns.

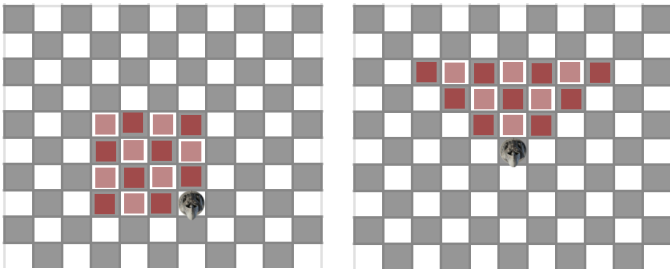
Movement

You can move a number of meters on your turn equal to your movement. 1 meter of movement corresponds to moving 1 adjacent square, including corners. If you have a flying speed, you may forego this movement to execute a number of *Maneuvers* dependent on the flying Gu being used. If you are under the effect of multiple Gu that grant a flying speed, you must choose one Gu and use the flying speed and number of Maneuvers granted by that Gu.

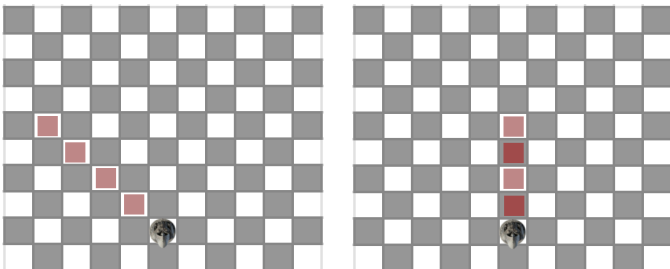
You can move through a [Small] or larger hostile creature's square with a successful **Dodge** skill test, but cannot end your turn inside another creature's square (unless they are [Tiny]). Failing a **Dodge** skill test made to move through a hostile creature's square expends your remaining movement.

Ranges

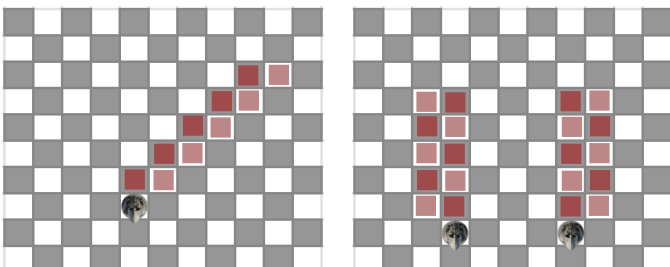
Valid 3-meter cones



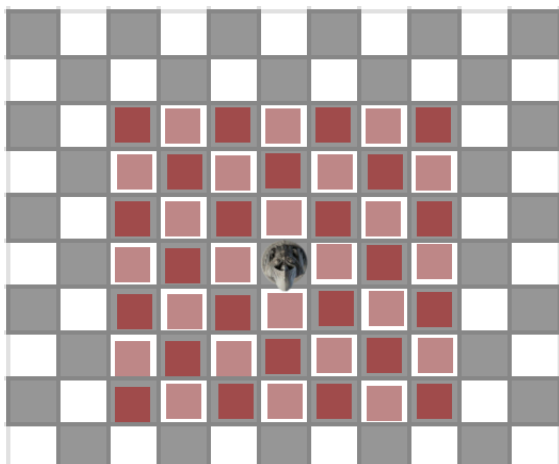
Valid 4-meter lines



Valid 5-meter long, 2-meter wide lines



A 3-meter radius



Targeted Attacks

The range of a targeted attack refers to how many meters of movement would have to be expended to reach the square of a valid target. This includes targeted area of effect attacks, such as lobbing a bomb to a square within range.

If an effect targets a creature, it can target anything living and capable of thought (i.e. no plants). Anything that isn't a creature or Gu is considered an object. If the effect just says to pick a target, the target can be a creature or object.

Touch

You must be within 1 meter of a creature to hit them with an attack with a range of *touch*. Touch attacks can be reacted to, but **[Shield]** Gu do not block touch attacks unless noted in the Gu's description, such as Jelly Bubble Gu. You can target yourself with Touch attacks.

Area of Effect Attacks

When a creature is caught in an area of effect, they can use the **Dodge Reaction**, escaping the area of effect if they succeed and are able to move outside the area of effect.

Cone

A 3 meter long cone will spread to any square that could be reached using 3 meters of movement between two adjacent diagonals or cardinal directions.

Line

Lines have a height, width, and length. If the height is not specified, it is the same as the width. Usually, lines originate from the square in front of the Gu Master creating it, but some Gu such as Fire Curtain Gu allow the user to choose a source square. In that case, the source and end of the line must both be within the range of the Gu.

Radius

Circular areas of effect will originate from a source square and have a radius. If an area of effect has a radius of 3 meters, it will affect the source square and any square that could be reached using 3 meters of movement from the source square. This translates to a square with a side length of 7 meters.

Jumping

Jumping costs half of your movement in meters, rounded up. If your movement is 0, you cannot jump.

Standing Jump

From rest, you can jump a maximum of 10% of your athletics skill (rounded down to a minimum of 1) in meters upwards, or 2 meters forwards.

Long Jump

If you move at least 1 meter in the direction of your jump before jumping, your forward jumping distance is equal to half your movement, rounded up.

Maneuvers

You may only execute a Maneuver if you have a flying speed. With the exception of *Take Flight*, you must be *airborne* to execute a maneuver. While *airborne*, you make **Dodge** skill tests with your **Flying** skill until you return to the ground, and use your flying speed when dodging. Penalties to your **Dodge** skill tests also apply to **Flying** skill tests made to dodge attacks.

Take Flight

Taking flight can only be done when on the ground. You rise a number of meters into the air equal to half your flying speed, rounded down, and are now *airborne*.

Fly

You move a number of meters equal to your flying speed in a straight line in any direction.

Dive

You must be at least 5 meters above the ground to perform a *Dive*. Make a **Flying** skill test. On a success, you dive down a distance of up to triple your flying speed, and can move up to your flying speed in meters forward. When you finish a *Dive*, you may make a single weapon or punch attack or activate a Gu with a range of touch targeting a creature within your melee range. Whether you do or not, you can try to execute a *Land* maneuver or else rise 1 meter directly upward at the end of the dive.

If you make a weapon or punch attack at the end of your dive, it deals additional force damage equal to your flying speed.

If you fail the test, you dive directly downward a number of meters equal to your flying speed before regaining control. If this would cause you to hit the ground, you do so, are no longer *airborne*, and take 4 force damage for every meter you dove.

Evade

Make a **Flying** skill test. On a success, all skill tests made to hit you with an attack are made with a penalty equal to +(50% of your flying skill, rounded down to the nearest multiple of 5) until the start of your next turn. You can only make one Evade Maneuver each turn.

Land

You land on solid ground. If executed at the end of a dive or atop *Difficult Terrain*, you must succeed a **Flying** skill test or else land *prone*.

Climbing

When climbing a surface, your movement is halved, rounded down to a minimum of 1 meter. If the surface does not have easy handholds like a ladder the GM may call you to make an **Athletics** skill test or else fall.

Swimming

Non-aquatic creatures consider water to be difficult terrain. A creature can hold its breath for a number of minutes equal to 10% of their Fortitude Attribute (rounded down) before falling unconscious. If the creature remains unable to breath for the same period of time after passing out, they die.

When a creature enters the water, they gain the *doused* condition.

Difficult Terrain

If a creature is standing in difficult terrain, it costs 2 meters of movement instead of 1 to move to another square.

Combat Actions

Activate Gu

Your Activations can be used to activate Gu as well as to utilize the lingering effects of many Gu, such as directing manifestations. You may activate a number of Gu equal to your **Activations** Attribute. You may activate each at any time during your turn, including in the middle of movement, but you cannot activate a Gu when it is not your turn. You may activate the same Gu multiple times, unless you are sustaining it. Using up your activations does not prevent you from activating Gu using your **Reactions**.

Activate a Killer Move

Pick a killer move for which you have all the Gu and enough primeval essence for all activations. For every activation in the killer move over your **Activations** Attribute, take 1 damage to your soul. The killer move activates, applying its effect. If the killer move has the [**Sustained**] keyword, you take 1 damage to your soul any time you activate a Gu while sustaining the killer move.

Melee Attack

Weapon Attack

Size	Modifier to Hit
Tiny	+40
Small	+20
Medium	0
Large	-20
Huge	-40

Roll a **Close Combat** skill test against an enemy within your weapon's range. On a hit, deal the damage of the weapon, +1 damage for every 20 points you have in Strength. Alternatively, you may forego a weapon

attack to throw a weapon with a thrown damage property. Thrown weapons have a range of 10 meters, +1 meter for every 5 points you have in Strength, and deal the weapon's thrown damage, +1 damage for every 20 points you have in Strength.

Multi-Weapon Fighting When wielding more than 1 weapon, you can make a number of weapon attacks equal to the number of wielded weapons instead of just 1. If you elect to do so, all weapon attacks made have a penalty equal to +(number of attacks * 10). You cannot wield more weapons than you have hands.

Unarmed Strike

When you take an unarmed strike **Combat Action**, you may make a punch attack for each arm you have, or a single kick attack or bite attack.

Punch: Roll a **Close Combat** skill test against a target within 1 meter. On a hit, deal 1 force damage, +1 damage for every 10 points you have in Strength. For every 5 damage dealt, even if it is reduced, you take 1 force damage directly to your hit points. Gu such as Metal Skin Gu and Copper Tendons Gu are typically used to prevent your own strikes from hurting you. At the Gamemaster's discretion, the recoil damage can be removed when punching a sufficiently soft target like Jelly Bubble Gu.

Kick: Roll a **Close Combat** skill test against a target within 1 meter. On a hit, deal 1 force damage, +1 damage for every 5 points you have in Strength. If the target is [Large] or smaller, it is knocked backwards 1 meter, +1 meter for every 100 points you have in Strength, and lands *prone*. Upon striking a creature or object, the target and the creature or object crashed into both take 1 force damage, +1 damage for every 100 points you have in Strength.

Bite: You viciously bite the target. Roll a **Close Combat** skill test against a target within 1 meter. On a hit, deal 2 rending damage, +1 damage for every 5 points you have in Strength. The target is inflicted with *bleeding* X, where X is equal to 20% of the rending damage dealt to their hit points, rounded down (to a minimum of 0).

Shove: You attempt to push a creature within 1 meter. You roll an **Athletics** skill test opposed by the creature's **Close Combat**. If you win, the creature is pushed backwards 2 meters. If you won by 3 or more degrees of success, they fall *prone*.

Grapple

Select an enemy of equal or lesser size in an adjacent square. Roll an opposed **Athletics** skill test against them. If you win, The creature is *restrained* and now occupies the same square as you while *restrained* in this way. While you are grappling a creature, you may not make kicking attacks and the number of free hands you can make punch attacks with using the **Melee Attack** action is reduced by 1.

You may expend your movement to make an **Athletics** skill test, with a +10 penalty for every 50 kilograms the grappled target weighs. On a success, you can move up to half your movement (rounded down).

As a **Bonus Action**, you can throw a target grappled by you as long as your Strength Attribute is greater than their weight in kilograms. The distance you can throw them is a number of meters equal to 5% of the difference between your Strength Attribute and their weight in kilograms, rounded down to a minimum of 1 meter. If the creature strikes another creature or object besides the ground, both take 3 force damage, +1 damage for every 10 points you have in Strength.

As a **Combat Action**, a grappled creature can attempt to break free, making an opposed **Athletics** skill test against the grappler. On a success, they break free.

Absorb Primeval Stones

On your turn, you can absorb the essence of a number of primeval stones equal to the number of hands you have. You must have one hand free for each stone being absorbed.

For each primeval stone being absorbed, you gain {30, 20, 10, 4, 1} portions of primeval essence, and the stone is destroyed in the process, crumbling into dust.

Hold an Action

You can choose to hold your **Combat Action**, specifying an action and a trigger for it to occur. When the trigger happens, you may use a **Reaction** to take that **Combat Action**. If you are reacting to an opponent's actions, you must make an opposed skill test to see whose action occurs first, with the skill in question being **Close Combat** if within 2 meters of each other, or **Ranged Attack** if not. If you hold the **Activate Gu** action, you may only specify a single activation.

Triggers can be specific or broad, ranging from "when the opponent uses Fire Pellet Gu" to "when a creature makes any hostile moves".

Sprint

Taking the sprint action triples your non-flying movement until the end of your turn.

Reactions

You can react to any action, event, or effect that you perceive, and may do so at any time, during your own or another creature's turn. Your total *Reactions* are replenished at the start of each of your turns up to your maximum (base 1 + 5% of your Agility, rounded down). You cannot use multiple *Reactions* to the same trigger, for example, dodging and activating a shield Gu when an attack hits you. Gu activations are imperceptible and cannot be reacted to; you must react to the effects of the Gu, such as when you're hit by an attack from it, an area of effect is created, or when an enemy is healed.

Reactions can be taken to any trigger, making the decision of when to use them a crucial part of combat. Since the Dodge *Reaction* moves you, it can be used when an enemy approaches to stay out of reach, or even on your own turn to close a bit more distance.

Activate a [Defensive] Gu

[Defensive] Gu can be activated as a **Reaction**, including after its determined an attack has hit you, but only before the damage has been dealt.

Dodge

The **Dodge Reaction** can be taken when its determined an attack has hit you and before the damage has been rolled. Make a **Dodge** skill test; if you succeed, you successfully dodge the attack and take no damage. If you fail, you are hit and take the full damage of the attack.

When you succeed the [Dodge](/rules/skills#dodge) skill test, you MUST move at least 1 meter and at most half of your movement (rounded down) in any direction, even through another creature's space (as long as you don't end in its space). If you succeed with at least 3 degrees of success, this movement does not have to be in a straight line. If you are unable to move, you

are also unable to take the Dodge **Reaction**. If half of your movement is insufficient to escape an area of effect attack, you are struck by the attack regardless.

If you use a **Reaction** to dodge for any trigger except an attack hitting you, you immediately move at least 1 meter and at most 1/2 your movement in any direction without making a skill test.

Dodging by moving out of a creature's melee range provokes attacks of opportunity, but the attack is made with disadvantage.

Parry

The Parry **Reaction** can only be taken when its determined a melee attack has hit you and before the damage has been rolled. Make a **Close Combat** skill test with a +10 penalty, opposing the opponent's attack roll. If you win, you take no damage from the attack and can make your own melee attack against the opponent in turn as long as they are within your melee range. You can parry attacks made as part of the Parry **Reaction**.

Make an Attack of Opportunity

You may make a melee attack as an attack of opportunity when a creature moves from inside your melee range to a square outside your melee range, or if a creature inside your melee range makes a **Ranged Attack** attack roll against a creature other than you. If you make an unarmed attack, it cannot be a kicking attack.

Flying out of a creature's melee range still provokes attacks of opportunity.

Trigger a Held Action

When the trigger you specified upon holding a **Combat Action** occurs, you may take this **Reaction** to use said action.

Detonate Gu Worms

As a **Reaction** or for free at any time during their turn, a Gu Master can self-detonate any Gu owned and refined by them with a single thought. The Gu Master must be conscious to do so, and can detonate as many or as few Gu as they want, from any distance. If the Gu is being suppressed, for example by the land spirit of a blessed land, the Gu Master cannot self-detonate it. Otherwise, the chosen Gu instantly die, with no other effects. If the Gu has a self-detonation ability, it does not trigger, since the Gu was not activated.

Bonus Actions

Bonus Actions are generally fast and low-effort, such as giving an ally a Gu from your aperture, opening an unlocked door, or pulling a lever.

Damage

When you take damage, subtract that amount from your current Hit Points, to a minimum of 0. When you hit 0 Hit Points, make a **Perseverance** Attribute test. On a failure, you are *Dying*. On a success, you enter *Final Stand*.

Damage Types

- Force: Being struck with an object or force, such as Qi; piercing attacks are included but generally have the **[Piercing]** keyword
- Rending: Being cut or slashed.
- Cold: Low temperature attacks
- Heat: Fire and heat
- Poison: Damage taken as long as you are *poisoned* by a source; reduce all poison damage dealt to a creatures hit points by 10% of their Fortitude, rounding down.
- Shock: Electricity damage.
- Sonic: Sound-based attacks that bypass many shield Gu but are quite rare and typically weak
- Direct: Direct damage can be of any damage type and, as the name suggests, deals that damage directly to a creature's hit points. If a source says it deals damage directly to a creature's hit points, the damage cannot be assigned to any active **[Shield]** Gu, but some effects may still reduce it. Damage from bleeding is always direct.

If a source says you take damage to your soul, that number is subtracted from your current soul value; you take no damage to your hit points.

Damage Reduction

Many defensive Gu reduce the amount of damage taken from attacks. When damage is reduced by a flat number, the damage can be reduced to 0 unless the source of the damage is of greater rank than the source of the damage reduction. If the source of the damage is of greater rank than the source of the damage reduction, the damage can be reduced to a minimum of 1. Damage reduction is applied before vulnerability and resistance.

If damage says it is unmitigatable, damage reduction does not apply to it. Damage is typically only unmitigatable if it is part of the cost of activating a Gu.

Vulnerability

(-1) Vulnerability: If you have vulnerability to a damage type, double all damage you take from that type to your hit points.

(0) Normal: You take the normal amount of damage to your hit points from this damage type.

(1) Resistance: If you have resistance to a damage type, halve all damage you take from that type to your hit points (rounded down).

(2) Invulnerability: If you have invulnerability to a damage type, you cannot take damage of that type to your hit points.

Rank Superiority

Higher-ranked Gu and killer moves always overpower lower-ranked ones. If you have vulnerability to a damage type from a rank 2 Gu and resistance or invulnerability to the same damage type from a rank 3 Gu, the higher-ranked effect completely overrides the vulnerability; the same is true the other way around, with a higher ranked source of invulnerability or resistance against a lower ranked source of vulnerability.

If you take damage from a Gu or killer move that outranks the source of resistance or invulnerability, your defense drops by one tier (Invulnerability drops to resistance; resistance drops to normal damage) for each rank of difference, to a minimum of 0 (normal damage).

Stacking Effects

When multiple resistance effects of the same rank are applied to a creature, sum the values of all of the effects, with a minimum of -1 and a maximum of 2, to determine how vulnerable you are to the damage.

For example, if you have vulnerability from 2 separate rank 2 Gu and invulnerability from another rank 2 Gu, $2 - 1 - 1 = 0$, so you take normal damage from that damage type.

Immunity

If you are immune to a condition, it cannot be applied to you regardless of the rank of the source. If you gain immunity to a condition while they have it, the condition is removed.

Instant Death

If you take an amount of damage equal to double your maximum hit points from a single source, you instantly die, and do not get to roll to see if you enter *Final Stand*.

Final Stand

While you have the *Final Stand* condition, you cannot move or take **Combat Actions** or **Reactions** other than to activate Gu, detonate Gu, or hold your action to do so. If you take any amount of damage to your hit points while in *Final Stand*, you enter the *Dying* state and fall *unconscious*. If you gain any hit points while in *Final Stand*, you are no longer in *Final Stand* and can act as normal.

Dying

If you are *Dying*, you are *unconscious*. At the end of each of your turns, roll a **Perseverance** Attribute test. On a success, you gain a **Perseverance Token**. On a failure, you gain a **Predicament Token**. Critical successes and fumbles grant 2 of the respective token. When you have 3 **Perseverance Tokens**, you are no longer *Dying* and instead enter *Final Stand*, and your **Perseverance** token count resets to 0. If you ever have 5 **Predicament Tokens**, you die. **Predicament Tokens** are permanent unless removed by a Gu.

Non-Lethal Damage

You may declare any melee attack to be non-lethal at any point up until the damage of the attack is dealt. If the damage reduces the target to 0 hit points, they roll to enter *Final Stand* like usual, becoming *unconscious* instead of *Dying* on a failure. If you deal damage to a creature in *Final Stand* with a non-lethal attack, they automatically fall *unconscious*.

Called Shot

When you make an attack roll against a creature, you can choose to pick a particular body part, worn or carried item, or manifested body parts like wings as the target of your attack. A called attack roll is made with a penalty based on the size of the target relative to the creature. So a creature's hands and feet will almost always be [Tiny], and their limbs [Small].

Fall Damage

When falling from a height of more than 2 meters, you take 3 force damage for every meter you fell.

Injury

When a creature takes damage to their hit points greater than or equal to half their maximum (rounded down), some damage types apply a special effect.

- Force:

d4	Effect
1 - Broken Arm	Unusable limb
2 - Broken Leg	-4 movement. If both legs are broken, your movement is reduced to 0.
3 - Internal Bleeding	<i>Bleeding 1</i>
4 - Concussion	<i>Dazed</i> . Cognition reduced by 15 for 3 days.

- Rending: *Bleeding 1*
- Cold: *Fatigued*
- Heat: *Burning*
- Shock: *Dazed*

Called Shot Injuries

When you make a called shot and successfully hit a specific body part, if at least 10 force or rending damage is dealt to the creature's hit points they take a corresponding injury.

- Hand: Broken Hand; disarmed and unusable
- Arm: Crippled Limb; Unusable
- Torso: Internal Bleeding; *Bleeding 3*.
- Leg: Crippled; -4 movement. If both legs are crippled, your movement is reduced to 0.
- Head: Roll 1d4

d4	Effect
1 - Brain Damage	Maximum Soul permanently reduced by 5
2 - Blinded	<i>Blinded</i> until the end of their next turn
3 - Hemorrhage	<i>Bleeding 5</i>
4 - Concussion	<i>Dazed</i> . Cognition reduced by 15 for 3 days.

Sleeping

When you sleep, you regain 1 hit point and 10% of your maximum soul for every hour spent sleeping (rounded down, but sleeping for 10 hours always restores your soul to its maximum). If you go longer than 16 hours without sleep, you gain the *fatigued* condition. Unless curing sleep-deprivation is explicitly stated to be an effect of a Gu, this condition cannot be removed by any means other than sleeping for at least 8 hours.

Every 4 hours you have this condition, you must make a **Perseverance** Attribute test with a cumulative +10 penalty for every time you've succeeded the test since the last time you slept. On a failure, you fall asleep on the spot.

Status Effects

Ablaze

A creature with the *ablaze* condition is completely engulfed in flames. An *ablaze* creature cannot have or gain the *burning* condition. If a creature with the *burning* condition gains the *ablaze* condition, the *burning* condition is removed. At the start of each of their turns, the creature takes 30 heat damage. If a human or variant human takes heat damage to their hit points on a turn from the *ablaze* condition, at the end of the turn they must succeed a **Perseverance** Attribute test or else fall unconscious. For creatures and Gu invulnerable or resistant to heat damage, consider damage dealt by the *ablaze* condition to be of the rank of the Gu that applied the *ablaze* condition, or rank 1 if the fire was natural. Being submerged in water removes the *ablaze* condition.

Airborne

An *airborne* creature cannot move or take the **Dodge Reaction**. If a creature has a flying speed when it becomes *airborne* from anything other than the *Take Flight* Maneuver, it may immediately fly up to half its flying speed in any direction. If a creature does not have a flying speed when it becomes *airborne*, it immediately falls up to 500 meters. If the creature is still falling, it falls 500 meters at the end of each of its turns until it hits the ground.

Bleeding X

Bleeding creatures take 1 damage directly to their hit points at the start of each of their turns for every stack of *bleeding*. This damage has no type and cannot be reduced by Gu, unless the *bleeding* condition is explicitly stated. Levels of *bleeding* can stack additively from the same or different sources. For every 5 hit points a *bleeding* creature restores, reduce the number of *bleeding* stacks they have by 1. If a creature is restored to their maximum hit points, they lose the *bleeding* condition.

Blinded

Blinded creatures cannot see, have a +40 penalty to **Dodge**, **Close Combat**, and **Ranged Attack** skill tests, and cannot make **Awareness** skill tests that rely on sight.

Some effects like smoke and steam may say they obscure the vision of creatures inside. This does not give the creature the *blinded* condition; it means all other targets have full cover from them, until the creature leaves the area of effect or uses an **[Investigative: Sight]** Gu to see through the effect.

Burning

Burning creatures take 10 heat damage at the start of each of their turns. For creatures and Gu invulnerable or resistant to heat damage, consider damage dealt by the *burning* condition to be of the rank of the Gu that applied the *burning* condition, or rank 1 if the fire was natural. Being submerged in water removes the *burning* condition. A creature can use their **Combat Action** to roll around on the ground, removing the *burning* condition.

Dazed

A *dazed* creature has their Activations Attribute reduced by 2 and gains a +10 penalty to all **Dodge** skill tests. At the end of their turn, they lose the *dazed* condition.

Deafened

A *deafened* creature cannot hear, has resistance to sonic damage regardless of the rank of the effect, and cannot make **Awareness** tests that rely on hearing.

Doused

When a creature gains the *doused* condition, they immediately lose the *burning* and *ablaze* conditions if they have one of them. A creature with the *doused* condition is vulnerable to shock damage, resistant to heat damage, and immune to the *burning* condition. If a *doused* creature takes heat damage, they lose the *doused* condition. The *doused* condition lasts for 10 minutes.

Fatigued

A *fatigued* creature's movement is reduced by 3 meters and makes all **Dodge**, **Cultivation**, and **Athletics** skill tests with a -30 penalty. The *fatigued* condition lasts until the creature rests for at least an hour.

Invisible

Both creatures and objects can be *invisible*, meaning they cannot be seen or targeted with attacks. **Dodge** tests made to avoid attacks from an *invisible* creature are made with a +40 penalty. **Dodge** tests to avoid attacks made with an *invisible* weapon or effect are made with a +20 penalty. These penalties can stack with each other, but only apply if the target cannot see *invisible* things with an **[Investigative: Sight]** Gu of high enough rank.

If a creature can detect an *invisible* creature via hearing, smell, or detect **[Investigative]** Gu, the **Dodge** penalty against their attacks is reduced to +20, and they become a valid target for attacks; attack rolls made against a detected *invisible* creature are made with a +20 penalty.

Poisoned

Poison can have any number of effects, and a creature can gain multiple instances of the *poisoned* condition so long as each is unique.

Prone

A *prone* creature has a +30 penalty to all skill tests and can only move 1 meter when they succeed a **Dodge** skill test. **Close Combat** skill tests made to hit a *prone* creature are made with a -10 bonus. **Ranged Attack** skill tests made to hit a *prone* creature are made with a +10 penalty. A creature can expend half their movement to stand up.

Restrained

A *restrained* creature's movement is 0. A *restrained* creature automatically fails all **Dodge** and **Flying** skill tests.

Stunned

A *stunned* creature cannot move or take **Combat Actions**, **Bonus Actions** or **Reactions**. At the end of their turn, they lose the *stunned* condition and gain the *dazed* condition.

Unconscious

An *unconscious* creature cannot act in any manner. If the creature is *unconscious* as a result of sleeping, they can make an **Awareness** skill test to wake up when they hear something, with a penalty or bonus depending on the proximity and loudness of the sound. Very loud noises like the sound of nearby combat automatically wake up a sleeping creature.

Creatures that gain the *unconscious* condition as a result of non-lethal attacks wake up after 1 hour.

Modifiers

High Ground

Ranged Attack skill tests are made with a -10 bonus if the target is at least 2 meters lower than the attacker in elevation.

Cover

If a creature is completely hidden behind cover from the attacker, they have full cover and typically are not a valid target for attacks. If the attacker uses a Gu with the [**Piercing**] keyword, however, they can make an attack against an obscured target with a +20 penalty. Gu that reveal the exact location of a target remove this penalty.

If a creature is only partially obscured by cover, they have partial cover; they are a viable target, but attacks made against them are made with a +10 penalty. If the attacker uses a Gu with the [**Piercing**] keyword, however, there is no penalty to the attack roll.

Light

Light sources specify how many meters of bright light they create in a radius around them. Dim light is emitted in a radius equal to twice the radius of bright light. For example, Little Light Gu emits 3 meters of bright light at all times, which means any square within 3 meters is in bright light, and any square between 4 and 6 meters away would be in dim light, with any squares beyond 6 meters still being in darkness. A creature in total darkness is considered *invisible* to any creatures that cannot see through that darkness. **Awareness** skill tests made to see a target in dim light are made with a +20 penalty.

Chapter 5 - Southern Border

Culture

Gu Immortals

When a Gu Master reaches the peak of rank 5, the aperture walls become completely impervious to primeval essence. The only way to further their cultivation is to find 3 different sources of Qi and gather them together, willfully crushing the mortal aperture and allowing the Qi to rebuild them. Heaven Qi, Earth Qi, and Human Qi need to be in perfect balance during the ascension process, and a failure means certain and permanent death. Heaven's Will also sends an Earthly Calamity and a Heavenly Tribulation against those that dare to seek greater understanding of Dao. But if the Gu Master is successful, they achieve rank 6, entering the realm of Gu Immortals. The aperture is transformed into an expansive landscape with features determined by the Gu Immortals' attainment in different paths. This new aperture can be entered by others, filled with wild beasts to multiply, and nurtured by the Gu Immortal to be a source of revenue and an escape from the world. They are typically called Blessed Lands, but rank 8 apertures are distinguished as Grotto-Heavens. These apertures often outlive the Gu Immortal's that gave birth to them, being placed in the world and becoming valuable resources to their Clan's Gu Immortals.

Geography

Notable Mountains

Wan Cheng Peak

Wan Cheng Peak is less than 10 kilometers from Tie Clan, and atop it is built the Demon Suppression Tower. Demon Suppression Tower is a prison hundreds of meters tall and houses thousands of demonic path Gu Masters. It has metal path Gu formations protecting it from attacks. Most prisoners are subdued with the rank 3 Aperture Lock Gu, but rank 4 and even rank 5 Gu Masters are suppressed through an assortment of different methods.

San Cha Mountain

San Cha Mountain is a collection of 3 peaks that rise into the sky like a pitchfork, with the middle mountain being the tallest. The area has some resources, and is often fought over by the Zuo and Che Clans. Unbeknownst to anyone, it is also the site of a combined inheritance belonging to three rank 5 Gu Masters, the Three Kings Inheritance. When the inheritance activates, pillars of light visible from across Southern Border shoot into the sky periodically from each peak, transporting potential inheritors from the peaks into the inheritance.

The Three Rivers

Jade Dragon River

Red Dragon River

Yellow Dragon River

Organizations

There are two types of major organizations in the Gu world: Clans and Sects. The four outer regions primarily follow the Clan system, wherein members of the Clan are related by blood. If you are born to a Shang clansmen, you inherit the surname "Shang" and are a member of the clan whether or not you awaken your aperture. Central Continent instead uses a Sect-based system wherein the sects each take disciples from all five regions and nurture them based on their talent and ethic. These are known as the Ten Ancient Sects.

Heavenly Court

The objectively strongest force in the Gu world is the ancient Heavenly Court. Heavenly Court is similar to the ten other Sects of central continent, but with an understood superiority over them. Founded almost 4 million years ago by Primordial Origin Immortal Venerable, the foundations of Heavenly Court are unfathomably deep. They are the protectors of the legendary rank 9 Fate Gu that controls the destinies of all creatures. Several Demon Venerables have attempted to destroy Fate Gu over the millenia, with Red Lotus Demon Venerable's attempt being the most notable as he actually managed to injure Fate Gu, weakening its iron grip on the destiny of the world. Heavenly Court's main objective now is to usher in the destined era of a new Venerable; Feng Jin Huang, the Great Dream Immortal Venerable and soon-to-be founder of Dream Path.

Heavenly Court usually uses the Ten Ancient Sects to exert its influence, and keeps out of mortal affairs as much as possible. They are far more concerned with the big picture, preventing the destruction of Fate Gu and foiling the plans of organizations like Shadow Sect that seek to resurrect the previous venerables.

Ten Ancient Sects

Immortal Crane Sect

Heavenly Lotus Sect

Ancient Soul Sect

Combat Immortal Sect

Heaven's Envy Manor

Spirit Affinity House

Black Heaven Temple

Spirit Butterfly Valley

Wind Cloud Manor

Myriad Dragon Dock

Super Clans

Ba Clan

"Our Tie cla

Shang Liang Mountain

Chai Clan

"Our Tie cla

Shang Liang Mountain

Chi Clan

"Our Tie cla

Shang Liang Mountain

Hou Clan

"Our Tie cla

Shang Liang Mountain

Qiao Clan

"Our Tie cla

Shang Liang Mountain

Shang Clan

Shang Liang Mountain stands tall in the center of Southern Border, the undisputed trade hub of the entire continent. Caravans owned by Shang Clan's many vassals travel millions of miles across Southern Border like a system of blood vessels, visiting a vast majority of the continent's clans. Shang Clan City is a bustling center of trade, importing goods from all 5 regions. It is also the only reliable place to purchase Guts Gu in Southern Border, making it a necessary stop for most Soul Path cultivators.

Tie Clan

"Our Tie clan, since it was established, had been world-renowned for our bravery, unswerving determination and our iron-cold justice. For many generations, Tie clansmen had been upholding justice and striking down on criminals, in this course, countless people have shed blood and sacrificed their lives. The youths that have died here won't be the first and also won't be the last." - Tie Mu Bai, Ch. 370

Tie Clan stands as a central pillar to the Southern Border righteous path. Their investigators are deployed to solve crimes across the entire continent, and thousands of demonic path Gu Masters guilty of vicious crimes are locked up in Tie Clan's **Demon Suppression Tower** atop Wan Cheng Peak.

Wu Clan

Wu clan is known as the top force in Southern Border, led by rank 5 Strength Path Gu Master Empress Wu Ji.

Xia Clan

"Our Tie cla

Shang Liang Mountain

Yang Clan

"Our Tie cla

Shang Liang Mountain

Yao Clan

"Our Tie cla

Shang Liang Mountain

Yi Clan

"Our Tie cla

Lin Chi Mountain, northeast

Commerce and Goods

The marketplace breathes life into a continent dotted with tens of thousands of isolationist clans. The caravan system disperses newly discovered Gu, beasts, and recipes into the economy, and great importance is placed on it by all Southern Border's righteous path. Robbing caravans is dangerous, and even the successful thieves are often hunted down by heroes or bounty hunters.

Makeup of a Caravan

Caravans vary greatly in size, but the smallest generally have 200 people. Shang Clan regulations require at least one rank 3 Gu Master on every caravan, but larger caravans are guarded by a rank 4. More Gu Masters are hired, split into teams, and assigned to sections of the caravan. The rest of the caravan's population is made up of mortals and slaves, used for menial labor. Rank 1 Gu Masters are given auxiliary roles, as the dangers posed to a caravan are often more than they can handle.

Refinement Recipes

Refinement recipes have a listed market value, but that doesn't necessarily mean the recipe is worth that amount. The market value assumes that this recipe is not available anywhere and there are no extenuating circumstances. But if you have a new recipe for Dog Enslavement Gu when the Three Kings Inheritance opens, the actual selling price will shoot up. Once you sell it the first time, however, the price will naturally go down somewhat. You can sell the same recipe as many times as you want, after all. Generally, the selling price is reduced by 75% every time it is sold.

Refinement Materials

Areas attuned with with the natural Dao generate plants, animals, stones, and other materials infused with a miniscule amount of Dao. These materials can be used to feed or refine Gu, and the areas that produce these materials are coveted by organizations and individuals. There also exist immortal refinement materials with higher amounts of Dao, but these materials are priceless compared to mortal materials and significantly rarer.

Gear

Armor

Armor is seldom seen in the Gu world, except when used by mortals. Armor is heavy and lacks the defensive strength of even some Rank 1 Gu, and thus has little demand. Still, some Gu Masters will use the effects of Gu to augment their armor for better protection.

When wearing armor, you gain a penalty to your **Dodge** rolls, but can soak up a bit more damage. Armor has a damage threshold and health statistic. Any force or rending damage dealt to you is reduced by the armor's damage threshold. Any force or rending damage dealt in excess of the damage threshold is dealt both to your hit points and to the armor's hit points. If the armor reaches 0 hit points, it breaks and becomes unusable. Shields must be wielded in at least one hand.

Armor	DT	HP	Dodge Penalty	Movement Penalty
Leather	4	20	+10	–
Iron	8	32	+30	1
Shield	4	15	+10	–

Weapons

Most weapons used by Gu Masters are manifested by Gu, but many Gu can improve the effects of common weapons. If a weapon has a V under its “hands” Attribute, it can be wielded in one or two hands, taking the former or latter damage number depending on how many you are wielding it with. You may change how many hands you are wielding a weapon with at any time during anyone's turn for free. Some weapons do increased critical damage, as indicated by the *Critical Multiplier* column.

Weapon	Damage	Range	Hands	Thrown Damage	Critical Multiplier
Dagger	6 rending	1 meter	1	6 rending	4x
Sword	8/12 rending	1 meter	V	–	3x
Spear	12/16 force	2/1 meter(s)	V	10 force	2x
Staff	6 force	2 meters	2	–	2x
Bow	–	–	2	–	4x

Thrown Weapons

Thrown weapons have a range of 5 meters, +1 meter for every 20 points you have in Strength, and deal 1 additional force damage for every 20 points you have in Strength. If the weapon does not have a Thrown Damage or is improvised, it deals 2 force or rending damage, depending on the sharpness of the weapon, and deal 1 additional force damage for every 20 points you have in Strength.

Throwing attacks have disadvantage on targets further than 30 meters from you.

Improvised Weapons

Items that are not intended to be used as weapons deal 4 force or rending damage, depending on the sharpness of the item, and deal 1 additional force damage for every 20 points you have in Strength.

Special Rules

A creature must be wielding a weapon with the proper number of hands to benefit from any special rules.

Bows

You must have arrows to make ranged weapon attacks with a bow. Arrows cost 1 primeval stone for a quiver of 30 arrows. Stronger characters can have bows specially made using durable refinement materials to increase their draw weight, making the weapon deal more damage and have longer range. You do not add your Strength Attribute to damage dealt with a bow.

Draw Weight	Minimum Strength	Damage	Range
20 kg	10	5 force	12 m
40 kg	100	10 force	24 m
60 kg	200	15 force	36 m
80 kg	300	20 force	48 m
cont.	cont.	cont.	cont.

Daggers

Daggers have a +40 penalty to attack rolls made to hit a creature wielding a sword, spear, or staff. Attacks made with a dagger against unaware or immobile creatures are automatically critical hits.

When a creature takes damage to their hit points from a dagger, they gain *bleeding 1*.

Spears

When a creature takes damage to their hit points from a spear, they gain *bleeding 1*.

Staves

You gain the Block **Reaction**.

Block

The Block **Reaction** can only be taken when its determined a melee attack has hit you and before the damage has been rolled. Make a **Close Combat** skill test opposing the opponent's attack roll. If you win, you take no damage from the attack; if you win by 3 or more degrees of success or via a critical, you regain the **Reaction** expended to Block.

Swords

Swords have a +20 penalty to attack rolls made to hit a creature wielding a spear.

You gain a -20 bonus to skill tests made to parry an attack. When a creature takes damage to their hit points from a sword, they gain *bleeding 3*.

Beasts

There are an uncountable number of different beast species across Southern Border. Some of the more common ones are listed in the *Flora and Fauna of Southern Border* supplement. Beast statblocks are somewhat different than Gu Master statblocks. Beasts are missing several skills and Attributes that they are incapable of using. As they do not have a Perseverance, when beasts reach 0 hit points they immediately die. They also do not have luck points, nor an aperture, and as such cannot activate Gu. Stronger beasts will have wild Gu worms living on or inside of them, however, and these Gu act independently, usually to assist the beast they live within. When the beast is in dire straits, however, most wild Gu will simply try to escape.

Rock Gambling

When wild Gu are near death, they sometimes will encase themselves in a fossil-like stone the size of a fist. Smooth stones of the proper size are dug out from the earth all over Southern Border and shipped to gambling dens to be opened. Usually the stones are empty or the Gu inside died many years ago, but they are also cheap and abundant, allowing a market where prices remain more or less static.

Grades

Gambling rocks are separated into grades by quality, going from D-grade to A-grade like Gu Masters. D-grade rocks rarely contain Gu and appear very ordinary, whereas A-grade rocks are attuned to specific dao and very commonly have Gu within.

Grade	Price (PS)	Live Gu %
A	20,000	20
B	2,500	15
C	500	10
D	20	5

A-Grade Odds

d20 Roll	Gu Rank
1-7	1
8-14	2
15-17	3
18-19	4
20	5

B-Grade Odds

d20 Roll	Gu Rank
1-9	1
10-15	2
16-18	3
19-20	4
-	5

C-Grade Odds

d20 Roll	Gu Rank
1-12	1
9-17	2
18-19	3
20	4
-	5

D-Grade Odds

d20 Roll	Gu Rank
1-15	1
16-19	2
20	3
-	4
-	5

Opening Rocks

To open a gambling rock is an art, requiring dexterity and experience. Normally Gu Masters use a Gu of rank 3 or lower that does some sort of damage and uses an attack roll to open up gambling rocks. The Gu used is at your's and the GM's discretion as to whether it would work, but once you find a Gu you'd like to use, you must spend 8 hours developing your rock opening technique. Make a **Deduction** skill test. On a success, you develop your technique.

Sample Technique

Duration: 5 minutes

Target Number: 10

For every degree of success on your skill test, increase the target number of the technique by 5.

To attempt to open a gambling rock, you must know a technique. Choose a technique and roll 1d100, comparing the number rolled to the Target Number of the technique, just like a skill test. If you succeed, the stone is successfully opened. Roll a d100 again and compare your result to the Live Gu % column of the Grades table. If you roll at or below, the stone contained a live Gu! Roll a d20 and compare it to the odds table of the appropriate grade to determine what rank the Gu inside is. If you fail, the rock is destroyed in the process, as well as any Gu that might have been inside.

You may extend the duration of your technique to an hour to gain a -20 bonus on the roll.

Improving Your Technique

For every 8 hours you spend opening rocks, the target number of the used technique is increased by 1. The target number of a rock-opening technique cannot exceed 99.

